



NOIDA HORROR

Minor girl gang-raped inside bus; two held

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Messi retires from international football

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ECONOMIC PICTURE

GDP growth stands at 7.8% in first quarter

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DATA POINT

India's low rating on democracy index

V-Dem flags decline in autonomy of institutions

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SHOCK RESULT

Unseeded Navone ousts ailing Djokovic

SPORT » PAGE 17

INSIDE



U.S., Iran trade strikes for first time in weeks

TEHRAN U.S. President Donald Trump threatened to hit Iran “hard” after the two countries traded fire for the first time in over a month. Late on Sunday, the U.S. said it had carried out strikes on an Iranian island, with Tehran quickly retaliating by attacking U.S. military targets in West Asia. » PAGE 14



Diplomat, activist and teacher win 2026 Magsaysays

PHILIPPINES A Singaporean diplomat Tommy Koh (in photo) who led adoption of UN oceans treaty, a Myanmar activist who put his freedom on the line for democracy, and a former Bangladeshi teacher were named on Monday as the winners of this year's Ramon Magsaysay Awards. » PAGE 14

India rejects Hague's Indus Waters ruling

NEW DELHI Hours after the Permanent Court of Arbitration at The Hague said the Indus Waters Treaty remains “fully in force” and called on India to “observe its obligations”, the Centre rejected this, saying the “very establishment of this alleged arbitral body” was a “grave violation” of treaty. » PAGE 5

SC rejects appeal for disclosure on ethanol at pumps

NEW DELHI The Supreme Court on Monday refused to entertain a petition alleging an element of “silent compulsion” in the rollout of E20 petrol and seeking mandatory disclosure of the ethanol content in petrol sold at fuel stations across the country. » PAGE 5

After the ‘hottest’ Aug, outlook for Sept. rain bleak

NEW DELHI India is likely to experience below-normal rainfall in September, with the India Meteorological Department (IMD) on Monday forecasting rainfall across the country to be at least 9% short of the long-period average of 167.9 mm. This comes after India experienced the hottest August since 1901.» PAGE 6

Ensure peace, freedom of navigation, PM urges Iran

Modi meets Iran President on sidelines of SCO summit, calls for stability in West Asia; Pezeshkian requests India to use its ‘extensive contacts’ to help with the dialogue process, blames U.S. for war

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

In the first top-level meeting between Iran and India since the beginning of the war on Iran in February, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday met Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian in Kyrgyzstan’s Bishkek and urged him to ensure peace and stability in West Asia and freedom of navigation in the Strait of Hormuz.

Mr. Pezeshkian blamed Israel and the U.S. for the conflict and requested Mr. Modi to “use India’s extensive contacts with various parties” and help the dialogue process.

After the meeting that took place on the sidelines of the SCO summit, Mr. Modi said on X, “Reiterated our commitment to strengthening India’s long-standing friendship with Iran across diverse sectors. We want to expand and diversify our trade basket in the times to come. We had



Strategic meet: Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Iran President Masoud Pezeshkian in Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan on Monday. PTI

a discussion on the prevailing situation in the region. India will continue to support all efforts aimed at ensuring lasting peace.” The Ministry of External Affairs said Mr. Modi called for freedom of navigation and commerce.

“Civilians and civilian infrastructure, including commercial shipping and seafarers must not be harmed under any circumstances,” he said.

Mr. Modi said he looked

forward to welcoming Mr. Pezeshkian to India for the upcoming BRICS summit.

President Pezeshkian said his country had a “responsibility” to defend the Iranian people “from danger and insecurity and to create conditions necessary for them to achieve peace, tranquillity and security”. He said Iran was “focused on ensuring peace and security and resolving issues through dialogue and negotiations.”

Mr. Pezeshkian blamed Israel and the U.S. for creating “restrictions and obstacles” before Iran and said that “Despite the pressures and restrictions being imposed in an attempt to obstruct Iran’s relations with other countries, Tehran is ready to expand its cooperation with India.”

He referred to the talks with the U.S. on a ceasefire and said, “The Islamic Republic of Iran has remained committed to the obligations it has undertaken within the framework of the agreements, but unfortunately, the American side has failed to fulfil its commitments.”

In June, Mr. Pezeshkian had invited Mr. Modi to the funeral of the slain Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei that was held in July. India was represented by a team that included the Governor of Bihar Lt. Gen. Syed Ata Hasnain (retd.).

RELATED REPORT ON
» PAGE 5

Breaking gender norms



Dry run: Members of the Nirbhaya Mahila Govinda Pathak held a rehearsal in Chunabhatti, Mumbai, on Monday as they prepare for the Dahi Handi festival, which will be celebrated on Saturday. EMMANUAL YOGINI

Manipur Deputy CM, 8 MLAs threaten to walk out of govt.

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Manipur Deputy Chief Minister Losii Dikho has urged the Union government to take punitive measures against fellow Deputy Chief Minister Nemcha Kipgen for “colluding” with a Kuki insurgent group allegedly involved in the killing of Naga civilians.

Mr. Dikho and eight other Naga MLAs also threatened to pull out of the Bharatiya Janata Party-led government in Manipur if no action is taken against Ms. Kipgen and the leaders of Kuki-Zo extremist groups.

Five of these MLAs, including Mr. Dikho, are from the Naga People’s



Losii Dikho has accused his colleague Nemcha Kipgen, right, of colluding with an insurgent group involved in killing of Nagas. PTI



Front (NPF), two are from the BJP, one from the National People’s Party, and one is an Independent.

They listed their demands in a letter to Union Home Minister Amit Shah on August 29. “The letter

was hand-delivered today [Monday],” Mr. Dikho said.

In the letter, the MLAs demanded the arrest of Kuki-Zo leaders who publicly claimed responsibility for the killing and dismemberment of six Naga civilians,

Gunmen kill 3 Kuki villagers in Kangpokpi

GUWAHATI

Unidentified gunmen on Monday killed three Kuki villagers and injured four others along the same road in Kangpokpi district of Manipur, where four Liangmai Naga civilians were gunned down on August 27. » PAGE 4

whose mutilated bodies were recovered on June 10 – almost a month after they were abducted.

They also demanded the arrest of Thangboi Kipgen, the head of the extremist Kuki National Front

(Presidential) faction and Ms. Kipgen’s husband.

“Initiate action against Deputy Chief Minister Nemcha Kipgen as her office is colluding with the Kuki militant group led by her husband Thangboi Kipgen...” the letter from the group read. The Naga MLAs further demanded the immediate abrogation of the Suspension of Operation agreement that the Centre had signed with 25 Kuki-Zo rebel groups in 2008, citing alleged repeated violations and acts of terror against civilians.

‘Larger interest’

“When the mutilated bodies of the six Naga men are still unclaimed in protest against the non-arrest

of the perpetrators, another four Naga men were mercilessly killed in the IT road ambush on August 27, carried out by the Kuki militants,” the MLAs wrote, citing some other incidents of violence. They warned that if action were not initiated, they would be “unable to defend or adequately respond to the challenges raised by the public concerning our continued support to the Government of Manipur.”

“This step is being taken solely in the larger interest of the people of Manipur, and out of absolute necessity,” they further wrote.

Manipur had 10 Naga MLAs. One of them, N. Kayisii of the NPP, died in January 2025.

Nepal deaths surge to 939; over 3,900 still missing

Associated Press
KATHMANDU

Rescuers raced to free hundreds of workers believed to be trapped in tunnels at hydropower sites that were buried in mud by catastrophic flooding on the Nepal-China border, as the combined deaths in both countries surpassed 950.

Nepal’s disaster agency said on Monday that 939 deaths had been counted, with 3,925 people missing, including 592 foreigners.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 14

INBRIEF



Punjab employees’ protest: leader gets transfer order

The Punjab government on Monday transferred Sukhchain Singh Kherra, one of the prominent faces of the employees’ protest, from the administrative branch in the Punjab Civil Secretariat to the planning branch in Sector 33. He has now been posted outside the Punjab Civil Secretariat. The move drew criticism from the employees’ bodies, which are already demanding that the AAP government accept their various demands, including release of pending dearness allowance. PTI

NSF to protest against Centre’s Vande Mataram directive

The Naga Students’ Federation (NSF) called for a demonstration and march to the State Assembly on Tuesday to protest the Centre’s directive to compulsory singing of Vande Mataram at government programmes and official functions. The NSF claimed that the complete version of the National Song was not in keeping with the country’s secular principles, arguing that its devotional and religious imagery conflicts with the conscience of those belonging to non-Hindu communities. The NSF, in a statement, said that its members would hold a demonstration at Naga Solidarity Park, and then march towards the Nagaland Assembly before the commencement of the Monsoon Session. PTI

Bihar Minister will be expelled from LJP(RV) if charges true: Chirag

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas) [LJP(RV)] national president and Union Minister Chirag Paswan on Monday responded to allegations against party MLA from Mahua and Bihar Minister Sanjay Kumar Singh. A day after Janshakti Janata Dal (JJD) leader Tej Pratap Yadav demanded a probe into the allegations, the LJP(RV) chief said he would expel Mr. Singh from the party and “strictest action” would be taken against him if the “very serious” allegations are found to be true. The party has sought an explanation from Mr. Singh, he said. Mr. Yadav had claimed

JJD leader Tej Pratap Yadav had demanded a probe into the allegations against Sanjay Singh

on X that the State Minister allegedly behaved indecently with a woman and attempted to exploit her in a Delhi hotel. The incident was allegedly “hushed up” with a payment of about ₹25 lakh, he added. Meanwhile, Mr. Singh has sent a legal notice to the JJD leader seeking an unconditional apology and ₹50 crore in damages for making “false” allegations against him on social media. He has sought a response within seven days.

Goa govt. stalls plan to table anti-conversion Bill in House amid pushback from within

Move comes after opposition from minority MLAs; no instances of forced religious conversions in State and hence no need for such a legislation, says Independent MLA and coalition partner

Press Trust of India
PANAJI

In a U-turn following pushback from legislators from the minority community, the Goa government on Monday decided not to introduce its anti-religious conversion Bill during the ongoing Monsoon Session of the State Assembly.

Chief Minister Pramod Sawant conveyed the decision after a meeting with BJP MLAs Michael Lobo and Delilah Lobo and Independent legislator Aleixo Reginaldo Lourenco on the opening day of the three-day session.

Mr. Lourenco, who backs the BJP-led government, said Mr. Sawant assured the legislators that the Goa Prohibition of Unlawful Conversion of Religion Bill, 2026 would not be tabled in the ongoing session. “I had made my stand clear that, if the government tables it, I will oppose it,” the Curtoim legislator told reporters.

There was no need for such a legislation in Goa,



Chief Minister Pramod Sawant conveyed the decision after a meeting with BJP MLAs Michael Lobo and Delilah Lobo and Independent legislator Aleixo Reginaldo Lourenco day. FILE PHOTO

he asserted, claiming that the government data showed no instances of forced religious conversions in the State.

Strong assurance

Mr. Delilah Lobo, who attended the meeting, also confirmed that the government would not introduce the Bill in the House.

The development comes days after the State Cabinet approved the pro-

posed legislation, which seeks to prohibit religious conversions allegedly carried out through force, coercion, undue influence, allurements, fraudulent means or marriage.

It proposes stringent punishment, including imprisonment of up to life, a minimum fine of ₹50,000 and compensation of up to ₹5 lakh for victims. The Bill also stated that a marriage could be declared void if it

was found to have been solemnised solely for unlawful conversion. It prescribed enhanced punishment in cases involving minors, women, persons with disabilities or mental illness, and members of Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes.

The Bill had sparked opposition from the Congress and Aam Aadmi Party, who had argued that it could create communal disharmony in Goa.

Questions need for law Christian organisations said they opposed forced or fraudulent conversions but questioned the need for a separate law, arguing that such acts were already punishable under existing criminal laws.

According to government data presented in the Assembly earlier this year, four cases of illegal religious conversion or attempts were registered in Goa between 2021 and 2025 – two each in 2022 and 2023 – with no such cases recorded in 2021, 2024 and 2025.

U.P. govt. to appoint Gen Z reel makers as cultural ambassadors

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

The Uttar Pradesh government on Monday announced a campaign to engage Gen Z content creators to promote tourism under the ‘Visit My State Uttar Pradesh’ campaign. It has invited participants to share 60-second reels showcasing what makes their city special. The winners will be appointed cultural ambassadors of their cities.

“As Gen Z increasingly shapes digital culture and travel discovery, the government is looking to give young residents a new role as cultural ambassadors. From heritage, culture, food and traditions to people, hidden gems and unique experiences, the campaign seeks to highlight destination stories through those who know these places closely,” read a statement by the Tourism Department.

The government said the choice of reels reflects a wider change in how younger audiences discover destinations.

“Short videos, personal recommendations and creator voices increasingly shape travel conversations, helping established attractions and local experiences



Gen Z is increasingly shaping digital culture, said the State Tourism Dept. FILE PHOTO

reach wider audiences.

The campaign seeks to direct this digital interest towards local culture, tourism and pride in one’s city,” it added.

Culture, traditions

“A resident of Lucknow, for instance, can speak about its cuisine, *chikankari*, old neighbourhoods or cultural spaces, just as participants from Braj, Bundelkhand, Purvanchal and the Terai can showcase traditions and experiences from their own cities,” the Tourism Department said.

It added, “By using a format familiar to young digital users, the government aims to make tourism promotion more participatory and bring local stories into wider circulation.”

Kanthapuram’s directive on women triggers row in Keralam

Abdul Latheef Naha
MALAPPURAM

A recent directive by veteran Sunni leader Kanthapuram A.P. Aboobacker Musliar on Muslim women’s participation in public religious celebrations has triggered a political controversy in Keralam and opened a fresh rift between his group and the Communist Party of India (Marxist) [CPI(M)].

Mr. Kanthapuram, general secretary of the Samastha Kerala Jamiyyathul Ulama and Grand Mufti of India, in the circular asked mahals and madrasas under Samastha to ensure that religious programmes follow Islamic norms.

The circular also asked them to prevent women from sharing stage or public space with unrelated men during religious celebrations. It advised against

incorporating customs from other cultures into Islamic festivals. Mr. Kanthapuram later reiterated the position at a meeting in Kochi. He said women should remain at home and argued that their entry into the public sphere could lead to “chaos”. He cited purdah as a means of preventing such problems.

Drawing flak

The remarks drew criticism from CPI(M) leaders and women’s organisations. CPI(M) Central Committee member P.K. Sreemathy called for the withdrawal of the circular while former Minister K.K. Shailaja said keeping women confined to homes was a “feudal practice”.

All India Democratic Women’s Association leader C.S. Sujatha and Students Federation of India (SFI) State secretary P.S.



Sunni leader Kanthapuram A.P. Aboobacker Musliar. FILE PHOTO

Sanjeev also criticised the directive. Former Minister A.K. Balan said the CPI(M) would oppose Mr. Kanthapuram’s position even if the Prophet himself came and made such a statement. State Women and Child Development Minister and Congress leader Bindhu Krishna said such views could push women “centuries back” and stressed their constitutional right to participate in public life.

State Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala also said he did not support restricting women in public spaces.

Defending remarks

The criticism has drawn a strong response from the Kanthapuram faction. Sunni Yuvajana Sangham State general secretary Rahmathulla Saqafi Elamaram defended the directive in an article in *Siraj*, the mouthpiece of the Kanthapuram Sunni faction.

Mr. Elamaram said the directive concerned the internal religious practices of Muslims and was not a restriction imposed on society as a whole. He said Islamic celebrations had a spiritual purpose and that young men and women singing and dancing together could shift the focus towards entertainment. He also rejected the charge

that Mr. Kanthapuram’s position was anti-woman. The article turned directly against the CPI(M), questioning the intervention of Ms. Sreemathy and Ms. Shailaja and accused them of showing “selective concern” for Muslim women.

Mr. Elamaram also accused the Democratic Youth Federation of India and SFI activists of using the controversy to divert attention from an internal dispute within the Left Democratic Front over the Assembly post of Deputy Leader of the Opposition.

The exchanges mark a departure from the long political and social association between Mr. Kanthapuram and the CPI(M). His associates have asked CPI (M) leaders not to interfere in religious matters. The CPI(M) has continued to frame the issue as one of women’s rights and public

participation. The dispute has moved beyond the wording of the circular to a wider argument over religious autonomy, gender rights and the meaning of progressive politics.

IUML takes no position

The Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) has not taken a public position on the directive. Local Administration Minister K.M. Shaji declined to comment on the issue. The row has remained largely an exchange between the Kanthapuram faction and CPI (M) leaders and organisations, with no major public challenge from the IUML or other Muslim groups.

Meanwhile, the Kerala Muslim Jamaat district committee has slammed Ms. Sreemathy and Youth Congress leader Jinto John for social media posts criticising the circular.

Green-blue infrastructure and heritage: building a resilient and timeless Delhi

OPINION

A city’s greatness is measured as much by what it safeguards as by what it builds. On that count, Delhi has few equals. Its ecological wealth spans the Yamuna and its floodplains, the Ridge, urban forests and biodiversity parks, while its cultural wealth lives on in monuments, historic precincts, and archaeological sites that span centuries.

With the country working towards the Prime Minister’s vision of Viksit Bharat 2047, Delhi carries the responsibility of showing how a fast-growing metropolis can pursue development alongside environmental restoration and heritage conservation. The Master Plan for Delhi (MPD) 2047 gives the national capital a framework to put both at the centre of its future.

Nature as core infrastructure Urban planning today operates under rules that climate change has rewritten. Higher temperatures, extreme rainfall,



Taranjit Singh Sandhu

Lieutenant-Governor of Delhi

Delhi carries the responsibility of showing how a fast-growing metropolis can pursue development alongside environmental restoration and heritage conservation

water stress, worsening air quality, and shrinking biodiversity all bear directly on residents’ health and daily lives. Rivers, forests, wetlands, lakes, and parks have moved beyond the status of amenities: they now function as core urban infrastructure.

At the heart of MPD-2047 is a connected green-blue network that draws the Yamuna, the Ridge, forests, biodiversity parks, water bodies, drains, and neighbourhood parks into one ecological system.

Urban forests and green corridors filter the air, cool heat-trapped neighbourhoods, and give native species a place to thrive. Revived water bodies, wetlands, and floodplains recharge groundwater and help the city cope with intense rainfall. Parks, trails, and cycling routes support active living and give communities spaces they can reach. The aim is straightforward: nature should run through daily urban life, not sit apart from it in scattered green patches.

Any picture of Delhi’s future is incomplete without the Yamuna. The river has shaped

the city’s geography and civilisation for centuries, though rapid urbanisation has left its floodplains under unprecedented strain. MPD-2047 puts the Yamuna at the heart of this ecological renewal, proposing to protect, conserve, and ecologically restore close to 1,700 hectares of floodplain.

Pollution is to be addressed where it starts: drains emptying into the river will be intercepted and treated through upgraded sewage infrastructure, constructed wetlands and bioremediation, restoring the river’s ecological health, and the floodplain’s natural functions.

The ambition extends further than restoration: Delhi has to rebuild its relationship with the river. A planned 52-kilometre cycling corridor, with walking trails, green stretches and organised recreational areas, will bring citizens back to the waterfront, turning revived sections into lively public spaces without compromising their ecology. A restored Yamuna could serve as both an ecological lifeline and a landmark public space.

Standing alongside it is Delhi’s other ecological pillar, the Ridge, an extension of the ancient Aravali range. MPD-2047 plans to restore roughly 7,784 hectares of it, guided by native species and scientific ecosystem management. The point is not simply to plant more trees but to build healthier ecosystems that sustain local biodiversity and secure the national capital’s environmental balance over the long run.

A living heritage

Delhi’s heritage has few rivals among cities. Its forts, monuments, stepwells, archaeological remains, and historic precincts each carry the story of an era that helped shape the city. Modernisation makes protecting this inheritance more urgent, not less. Yet conservation cannot mean preserving buildings and neighbourhoods as if frozen in time. Heritage has to stay a living part of the city, tied to the lives and ambitions of the people who inhabit it.

Under MPD-2047, close to 1,500 heritage assets are to come under Cultural Resource

Management Plans, moving conservation from scattered efforts towards a structured, long-term system. Adaptive reuse is central to this: heritage buildings, carefully repurposed as museums, libraries, hotels, offices or cultural venues, stay useful to the city while their historic character remains intact.

A mix of planning and financial incentives, including Transferable Development Rights, façade retention and reasonable relaxation of space standards by the competent authority, subject to fire and life-safety norms, is meant to make conservation economically viable. It should be seen as an opportunity rather than a burden.

Heritage carries economic weight too: well-maintained historic areas draw tourism, create jobs, and open opportunities for local businesses. MPD-2047 proposes heritage, cultural and festival circuits linking monuments, precincts and public spaces, so visitors take in Delhi as a living historical landscape rather than a checklist of monuments.

Precincts active around the clock, supported by better public spaces and walkable streets, can sustain local crafts, hospitality, and cultural enterprise.

Real strength

What gives MPD-2047 its real strength is bringing ecological and cultural planning together. Many historic sites sit within or beside forests, water bodies, the Ridge, and the Yamuna landscape. Linking them through greenways, cycling paths, and revived water systems builds a complete urban experience: water bodies as community spaces, green corridors joining neighbourhoods to biodiversity parks, residents cycling beside a restored river, and historic precincts humming with culture and commerce. As India works towards Viksit Bharat 2047, Delhi has to show that development and conservation reinforce rather than oppose each other. A Viksit Dilli cannot measure itself by growth alone. It must breathe easier, live healthier, and honour the heritage that gives it a soul.



Minor girl gang-raped on moving bus in Noida

CM YK A IN-X

‘Hydrocarbon exploration scheme to benefit Adani’

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Alleging that the Centre’s ₹84,084-crore Samudra Manthan scheme for off-shore hydrocarbon exploration was designed to benefit the Adani Group, the Congress on Monday demanded that it either be scrapped or that its entire outlay be diverted to the public sector Oil and Natural Gas Corporation (ONGC).

Addressing a press conference here, Congress spokesperson Shaktisinh Gohil said the Union Cabinet approved the scheme last month for its first phase, and claimed that it had created a framework under which companies undertaking offshore exploration, including Adani-owned Well Spun Exploration Ltd. (AWEL), would receive substantial financial support from the government.

Mr. Gohil asked why ONGC, which had decades of experience in hydrocarbon exploration, was not being given the primary role in the national mission.

There was no response from the government or the Adani Group to the Congress’s allegations.

PM calls for ‘end of war’ at meeting with Putin

The two leaders discuss conflicts in West Asia and Black Sea region, impact on maritime trade and safety of Indian seafarers; Putin highlights positive trends in Moscow-New Delhi economic ties

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday met Russian President Vladimir Putin on the sidelines of the SCO summit in Bishkek and said the world “must move from endless war to end of war for the benefit of humanity”.

The External Affairs Ministry said the two leaders discussed conflicts in West Asia and in the Black Sea region, where, in recent months, Indian seafarers have been attacked by both Russian and Ukrainian forces.

“Had extensive discussions with President Putin. Discussed the full range of the India-Russia Special and Privileged Strategic Partnership. It is gladdening to see significant progress across various sectors in recent years. Focus areas for India-Russia friendship remain energy, innovation, space, fertilizers, and people-to-people linkages,” said Prime Minister Modi.

In a statement, the External Affairs Ministry said,



Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Russian President Vladimir Putin during a meeting in Bishkek on Monday. ANI

Number of Indian students in Russia increased almost seven-fold in a decade, says Putin

“They also shared perspectives on key regional and global issues of mutual interest, including the conflicts in West Asia and the Black Sea region which have impacted maritime trade and the safety and security of Indian seafarers. Prime Minister reiterated that dialogue and diplomacy was the way forward in

resolving conflicts.” The upcoming BRICS summit featured prominently in the discussion, and Mr. Modi said he “looks forward to welcoming President Putin in India for the 18th BRICS summit on 12-13 September”.

80th anniversary of ties The Bishkek meeting between Mr. Modi and Mr. Putin featured in talks during External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar’s visit to the Kremlin on August 24, when Mr. Putin had indicated that he would meet Prime Minister Modi in

Kyrgyzstan and also at the BRICS summit in Delhi.

“This time, our meeting is taking place on the eve of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation Summit - an organisation that works to deepen contacts among the countries of the Global South and East, promotes the region’s socioeconomic and cultural development, and contributes to building a just multipolar world,” said President Putin in his remarks, reminding that next year will mark the 80th anniversary of establishment of diplomatic relations between New Delhi and Moscow.

Mr. Putin noted that the number of Indian students in Russia has increased almost seven-fold in a decade, and currently 40,000 Indians are studying in Russia.

President Putin said trade and economic cooperation between Russia and India is showing positive trends, with trade turnover increasing by more than 2%. He noted the growth in tourist exchanges between the two countries, with a 16% increase in 2025.

India rejects Hague court’s Indus Waters Treaty ruling, says it has no jurisdiction

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

Hours after the Permanent Court of Arbitration at The Hague said the Indus Waters Treaty remains “fully in force” and called on India to “observe its obligations”, the External Affairs Ministry rejected this, saying that the “very establishment of this alleged arbitral body” was a “grave violation” of the treaty.

“This so-called Court was constituted by the World Bank in patent breach of the terms of the Treaty, and India categorically rejects its so-called award,” the Ministry said on Monday.

It went on to say that India had “never recognised the existence in law of this illegally-constituted and so-called Court of Arbitration, and has consistently maintained that the very establishment of this alleged arbitral body constitutes a grave violation of the Indus Waters Treaty”.

“Accordingly, India has never appeared before this body and has refused to take any cognisance of its earlier pronouncements,” the Ministry said. India had placed the In-



India had placed the treaty in abeyance following the Pahalgam terror attack.

dus Waters Treaty “in abeyance” following the Pahalgam terror attack on April 22, 2025, and the Ministry, in its response on Monday, reiterated its position. “India’s decision to hold the Indus Waters Treaty in abeyance remains in force,” it said.

The Ministry also said that “this so-called Court of Arbitration has no jurisdiction whatsoever to pronounce on India’s sovereign decisions”.

It added that the court’s pronouncements, “now or in the future, will have no effect on India’s actions in connection with the projects being undertaken by India”.

Earlier, the arbitration body, considering Pakis-

tan’s plea, examined the reasons under which India placed the treaty “in abeyance” and said that “none of these grounds could justify suspension or termination of the Treaty”.

Issuing an “award” on the ‘Status of the Indus Waters Treaty and Order on Interim Measures concerning the Ratle Hydro-Electric Plant (RHEP)’, the Permanent Court of Arbitration said, “Accordingly, the Indus Waters Treaty remains fully in force, and India must observe its obligations under the Treaty, including those relating to the design and operation of its hydro-electric projects on the Western Rivers.”

It had also considered Pakistan’s plea on imposing measures on India regarding the RHEP, saying, “In a unanimous decision, the Court decided to impose measures prohibiting India from concreting the RHEP dam wall and power intake structure above certain levels until 90 days after the Neutral Expert’s final decision, which is expected in July 2027.”

The Court of Arbitration is chaired by Prof. Sean D. Murphy of the U.S.

FIR against Rahul exposes BJP’s casteist mindset: Cong.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

After the Uttarakhand Police registered a case against Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi over his remarks on the “purification” ceremony which “insulted” Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, the party on Sunday said it “exposed BJP’s casteist mindset”.

Congress general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal announced that party workers across the country would take to the streets on Monday evening to demand “prosecution of the BJP leaders who insulted Khargeji and to defend our Constitution against

the BJP’s assault on its values of social justice”.

The party described the first information report (FIR) against Mr. Gandhi as an attempt to divert attention from the allegations of caste discrimination and suppress the voices demanding action against those involved in the purported “*shuddhikaran*” (purification) ceremony at the venue of Mr. Kharge’s public meeting in Haldwani in Uttarakhand.

“What is worse is that the BJP jumped in to defend this abhorrently casteist behaviour, showing to the entire world that they are the biggest perpetrators of social injustice today,” Mr. Venugopal said. He alleged that the BJP



K.C. Venugopal

was willing to deploy the “entire might of the State” against those who spoke out against atrocities committed against Dalits.

“What the BJP has done is to attack the values of social justice enshrined in the Constitution, and the Congress will fight against this attack tooth and nail,” he said. “We will not rest

until the true culprits of the insult to Khargeji are punished, and this frivolous FIR against Rahulji is thrown in the dustbin.”

Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh said Mr. Gandhi had raised the issues of injustice, humiliation and discrimination faced by Dalits, and alleged that the BJP-RSS had “proved him right” within 24 hours.

‘Bid to divert attention’ “This is the very mindset against which Babasaheb’s Constitution stands as the greatest wall,” Mr. Ramesh said, alleging that the BJP was seeking to divert attention and suppress dissent. Congress general secretary in charge of Uttarak-

hand Kumari Selja questioned why no FIR had been registered against those who allegedly conducted the ritual.

“No action against those who conducted the ‘purification’ ritual after Congress President Shri Mallikarjun Khargeji’s public meeting, but an FIR against Leader of Opposition Shri Rahul Gandhiji for raising his voice against that casteist act. Is this the justice of the BJP government?” she asked.

The Congress’s Scheduled Castes department chairman Rajendra Pal Gautam alleged that the incident amounted to a violation of the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of

Atrocities) Act and questioned the police’s failure to act against those allegedly responsible.

On the issue of FIR, BJP spokesperson Gaurav Bhatia said at a press conference: “There has never been, nor will there ever be, a leader in India more irresponsible and more anti-Dalit... than Rahul Gandhi. He should introspect.”

The BJP leader said that after Mr. Kharge alleged that he had been insulted, Mr. Gandhi did not take notice of it for three weeks. “Rahul Gandhi has time to travel around the world. However, when someone from the Dalit or backward community makes an allegation, he himself does not take it seriously,” he said.

SC rejects petition for mandatory ethanol disclosure at pumps

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday refused to entertain a petition alleging an element of “silent compulsion” in the rollout of E20 petrol and seeking mandatory disclosure of the ethanol content in petrol sold at fuel stations across the country.

A Bench of Justices M.M. Sundresh and Prasanna B. Varale was hearing a petition by advocate and petitioner-in-person Narendra Kumar Goswami, contending that consumers were

entitled to know the composition, quality, standards and compatibility implications of the fuel they purchase. Such disclosure, the plea said, was not a “decorative consumer slogan but a constitutional requirement when the State itself creates a nationwide compulsory market”.

The Bench declined to entertain the plea, observing that the petitioner could approach the competent authority with his grievance instead of directly moving the Supreme Court.

After SC refusal to halt CJP march, police seek quashing of FIRs against protesters

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

Within hours of the Supreme Court refusing on Monday to halt a protest march announced by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) in central Delhi ahead of the BRICS Summit, the Delhi Police moved an urgent plea to quash first information reports (FIRs) registered against students and youth who participated in the NEET-UG paper leak protests.

Days before the BRICS Summit on September 12-13, the CJP decided to hit the streets again on September 5, citing the Centre’s failure to live up to its assurances, including the immediate withdrawal of FIRs against student protesters.

Earlier in the day, a three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant found no “compelling circumstance” to interfere with CJP’s plans for a protest march.

In the afternoon, as the Bench was preparing to rise for the day, Solicitor-



The Delhi Police said it did not wish to pursue FIRs registered after the crackdown on July 20.

General Tushar Mehta orally mentioned an application filed by the Delhi Police urging the apex court to invoke Article 142 of the Constitution to quash the FIRs. Mr. Mehta pushed for a hearing on September 1 itself.

The Delhi Police said it “no longer wished” to pursue the FIRs registered across various police stations in central Delhi against students and protesters following the crackdown on July 20. These FIRs had arraigned charges of rioting, attempt to murder, and damage to public property against protesters.

Billboard row: police, fire officials inspect Abhishek’s office

Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA

A joint team of Kolkata Police and Fire Department officials on Monday visited the Camac Street office of Trinamool Congress general secretary Abhishek Banerjee to conduct a fire safety audit and examine the building plan.

The visit came only four days after a team of Kolkata Municipal Corporation (KMC) officials and Kolkata Police visited the premises to remove an electric billboard that also led to a clash between the officials and the party workers.

On Monday, Fire Department officials inspected the safety arrangements at the premises. Officials from the department however cited it a routine exercise and that the premises would be assessed based on applicable fire safety and building norms. They also stated that a few more inspections may also be conducted to examine to the building plan.

The visit comes amid a political controversy over Mr. Banerjee’s Camac



Abhishek Banerjee

Street office, with the Trinamool alleging that repeated “actions by the administration were politically motivated”.

Trinamool-KMC scuffle A scuffle between the Trinamool leader and KMC officials and the police personnel had erupted on August 27 night when the KMC personnel forcibly removed a billboard from a building in area where the party office is located. A billboard reading ‘All India Trinamool Congress’ was put on the top of a building located at 9 Camac Street, a large part of the premises serves as the office of Mr. Banerjee.

Two suspects shot dead in police encounter over Haryanvi singer’s murder

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Two alleged sharpshooters involved in the murder of Haryanvi singer Ankit Balyan were killed in an encounter with a Special Weapons and Tactics (SWAT) team and police personnel from Shamli district, the Uttar Pradesh police said on Monday. The two men, identified as 24-year-old Sumit and 22-year-old Mohit, carried a reward of ₹50,000 each. A search for the other two accused is under way, said the police.

The singer’s father welcomed the development and said the killing of the other two accused would bring the family “complete justice”.

Balyan was shot dead outside his gym in Shamli by four motorcycle-borne assailants on August 26. Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav had hit out at the State government over the incident, calling it an attack on the Jat community.



RLD chief Jayant Chaudhary meeting the family of slain Haryanvi singer Ankit Balyan in Shamli on Monday. PTI

On Monday, Union Minister and Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD) chief Jayant Chaudhary, who hails from the community, met the family in Banti Kheda village and said there should be faith in the police.

“Mohit and Sumit were injured by gunfire during retaliatory firing by the police in self-defence in a joint operation by Kotwali Shamli police station, Jhinhana police station and SWAT team,” read a statement issued by the police.

The statement added that they were taken to

Shamli Joint Hospital, where the two died during treatment.

Two head constables were injured in the gunfire, the police said, adding that three pistols, 26 live cartridges and a motorcycle, among other items, were recovered from the crime scene.

“It has been learnt that about 14 cases were registered against Mohit and 1 case against Sumit. Information regarding their criminal history is being ascertained,” the statement added.

The Indian Navy commissioned *INS Nipun* on Monday at the Naval Dockyard in Mumbai. It is the second Diving Support Vessel (DSV) of the Nistar class and will significantly enhance the Navy's capabilities in deep-sea diving, underwater intervention, and submarine rescue. Presiding over the ceremony was Chief of the Naval Staff Admiral Krishna Swaminathan. According to the Ministry of Defence, *INS Nipun* is a specialist platform built to undertake complex underwater operations. The vessel was indigenously designed and built by the HSL in Visakhapatnam. Its induction marks another step towards self-reliance in defence shipbuilding.

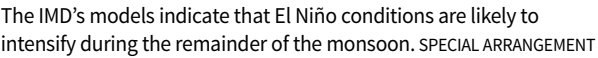
An Air India Express flight from Saudi Arabia's Dammam to New Delhi was diverted to Ahmedabad after a crew member discovered a tissue paper carrying a warning message of a "bomb" aboard the aircraft. After the aircraft landed in Ahmedabad, security agencies checked it and found nothing suspicious, said Assistant Commissioner of Police (ACP), 'G' Division, V. N. Yadav, according to *PTI*. The official said an investigation has been launched. The flight had 32 passengers, who were accommodated at Terminal 2 of the Ahmedabad airport. Air India Express said that the aircraft will be released for operations after necessary security checks are completed.

A Delhi court sentenced conman Sukesh Chandrasekhara to eight years of rigorous imprisonment last week for impersonating a Supreme Court judge and attempting to influence judicial proceedings to secure bail in another criminal case. Chief Judicial Magistrate Harshita Mishra of Tis Hazari court sentenced Chandrasekhara on August 29 under Sections 170, 189 and 507 IPC. According to the sentencing order, the accused made multiple calls to a judicial officer on April 28, 2017, allegedly posing as a Supreme Court judge from South India and using a regional accent to make the impersonation appear genuine.

A computer-based examination centre in Jaipur's Sitapura area came under scrutiny on Monday after technical problems disrupted an All India Institute of Medical Sciences recruitment exam, a day after an internal power failure at the same facility forced the cancellation of the NEET-PG 2026 exam for 2,445 candidates. The same ION Digital Zone facility was being used for the AIIMS Common Recruitment Examination-5. The institute cancelled the CRE-5 at two exam centres in Jaipur following a disruption caused by internal power supply issues, a source said. The AIIMS has also directed TCS, which operates the exam centres, to submit a detailed report.

He added that this marked the fourth water agreement between States this year, which would enhance water availability for irrigation, rural development and drinking purposes.

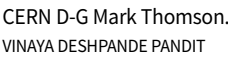
September brings in about a fifth of the June-September monsoon rain, less than July's 32% and August's 29%. In recent years, September rainfall has seen a relative uptick. As of August 31, India's cumulative monsoon rainfall was about 14% below normal, with central India in surplus but the northwest, east and northeast, and south peninsula all recording deficits. The shortfall was particularly pro-



IMD Director-General Mrutyunjay Mohapatra explained this as a consequence of the ongoing El Niño, which dries out the

Four low-pressure systems, precursors to cyclonic storms, and mostly originating in the Bay of Bengal,

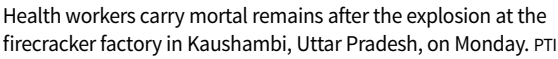
While answering questions on the future projects of the CERN, Mr. Thomson said the Future Circular Collider would push the boundaries of innovation, technology, and imagination. The Future Circular Collider would be a new 91-km ring, which is expected to be operational by 2045.



"Also, we are pausing for four years to bring a brighter version of LHC [Large Hadron Collider], which will be more powerful. We will use technologies we have not used before, because they were not there. In the very long term, we are looking at

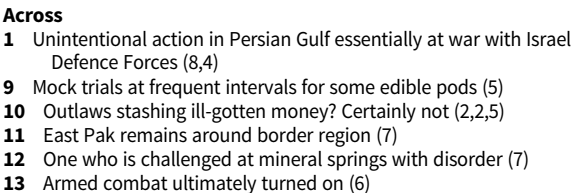
The IMD's models indicate that El Niño conditions are likely to intensify during the remainder of the 2026 southwest monsoon season. The IMD's July 31 outlook for August had indicated "below-normal" rainfall over much of the country, and said this "matched" observations over many regions.

Earlier, the matter had been referred to the third member, as the two-member Division Bench of Ashok Kumar Bhardwaj (Member Judicial), and Reena Sinha Puri (Member Technical), gave a split verdict on the repayment plan.



“Information was received about an explosion at a firecracker factory near Manori power house in the Pipri police station area. Police and fire brigade teams immediately

Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath expressed grief over the incident.



2	3	7	6	8	5	1	4	9
8	5	1	2	4	9	7	6	3
6	9	4	7	3	1	8	5	2
7	2	3	5	6	4	9	8	1
5	6	9	1	7	8	3	2	4
4	1	8	3	9	2	5	7	6
1	4	2	8	5	3	6	9	7
9	7	5	4	1	6	2	3	8
3	8	6	9	2	7	4	1	5

Most importantly, both works direct human beings towards spiritual liberation. Krishna teaches surrender to God as the means to transcend karma, maya, and samsara. Similarly, Tiruvalluvar speaks of crossing the "great ocean of birth" by reaching God's feet. Thus, the Bhagavad Gita and Tirukkural both guide humanity towards dharma, right action, devotion, self-discipline, compassion, and ultimately liberation from the cycle of birth.

What two districts can teach us about dealing with rural waste

Worldwide, around 2.7 billion people do not have their waste collected, and of them 2 billion live in rural areas, an analysis by the UN Environment Programme has found; where people cannot manage waste, they dump it on land or in rivers, streams, and seas, or burn it, a major concern in India

Mahima Jain
MAJULI/BENGALURU

On April 30, 2025, Bibhash Bormedhi looked on as a tonne of waste left Majuli on a boat across the Brahmaputra river. “This was the first time the waste from Majuli crossed the Brahmaputra, instead of being dumped into the river,” Mr. Bormedhi, Project Manager at waste management non-profit Sahaas, which led the initiative, said.

On Independence Day 2024, in Arunachal Pradesh’s Tawang District, villagers from Zemithang Circle sent away 4.4 tonnes of garbage in a lorry. Nestled in the folds of the Himalaya, between 6,900 feet and 8,000 feet high, they had segregated their waste for the first time. The truck made a 390-km journey lasting over 12 hours to scrap dealers in Tezpur, Assam.

Behind these efforts lay months of preparation, creative ways of financing, and a growing awareness that waste was becoming a mounting problem in the remotest corners of India.

‘Data does not exist’

The country produces 1.7 lakh tonnes of waste every day, per the Central Pollution Control Board. Of this, 22% ends up in landfills and 17% is unaccounted for. Activists groups and experts have said data on rural waste are simply not counted at all.

“Waste data for rural areas doesn’t exist,” said Siddharth Singh, programme manager, Solid Waste Management and Circular Economy, Centre for Science and Environment (CSE), New Delhi. Urban and rural local bodies are tasked with solid waste management and data collection, including volumes and expenses, but they rarely do the needful, Mr. Singh added.

Earlier this month, the Supreme Court pulled up the Union and State governments for not institutionalising the Solid Waste Management Rules 2026. The court ordered that regulatory bodies must be notified, staffed, and provided with the necessary infrastructure to function effectively.

Data show a rise in per-capita spending in India’s rural areas. More consumption also results in more waste.

“Food, beverages, personal care or hygiene products – almost everything is wrapped in plastics or multi-layered packaging,” Mr. Singh said. “These goods have penetrated the remotest rural markets.”

Waste management has not, however. Worldwide, around 2.7 billion people do not have their waste collected – and of them 2 billion live in rural areas, an analysis by the UN Environment Programme (UNEP) found.

Where people cannot manage waste, they dump it on land or in rivers, streams, and seas, or they burn it, which is a major concern in India.

“In Majuli, people used to throw the waste in their fields or in the river,” Brojen Pegu, a Majuli local, said. “When it flooded every year, the river carried the waste away.”

For centuries, organic waste was used to feed livestock or as manure. But more plastics and other non-biodegradable materials have led to a mixed waste today, which is harder to decompose.

Majuli’s method

Alakesh Gogoi, District Official, Swachh Bharat Mission and the Public Health Engineering Department, said his department built the Central Material Collection Facilities (CMCFs) in 19 of 20 panchayats and mini-collection facilities in most of the 160 villages between 2017 and 2022. However, neither were these tin sheds used nor were the workers mobilised. In 2024, Sahaas teamed up with the departments, he said.

A waste management system needs several other components besides CMCFs, according to Mr. Bormedhi.

Community participation goes hand-in-hand with operationalising collection and transportation.

Village leaders, homestay and hotel owners, schools and self-help groups participated in awareness programmes, and handed out bags for storage and segregation.

Simultaneously, the logistics of managing the non-biodegradable waste was fine-tuned, Mr. Bormedhi said.

This included funding, staffing, and training sanitation workers; arranging for vehicles for transport; operating the material collection facilities; and finding recyclers.



Women in Gobuk, Upper Siang, Arunachal Pradesh, gather for the monthly ‘Swachchata Divas’, a collection drive where the community brings and segregates its household waste. FURTHER AND BEYOND FOUNDATION/SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Today, garbage is collected in 19 of 20 panchayats despite the locals facing floods and erosion, Mr. Gogoi said.

A community-led model

In the land-locked and mountainous villages of Tawang, there was no escape for garbage.

Having sanitation workers collect garbage from door to door wouldn’t work here because the settlements are scattered, Alifa Zibrani, senior project coordinator with Himalayan Fringes Project, Further and Beyond Foundation, a nonprofit focused on community-led waste management, said.

Instead, in 2024, through the Project, local officials and village leaders came together to pilot a community-led model of waste management in Chullyu in Keyi Panyor district. Within two years, the model had been adopted by a third of Tawang district and parts of Keyi Panyor and Upper Siang districts as well.

“Every household is responsible for segregating biodegradable and

Data show a rise in per-capita spending in India’s rural areas, which also results in more waste; experts said that while ‘food, beverages, personal care or hygiene products’, almost all of which are ‘wrapped in plastics’, have ‘penetrated the remotest rural markets’, waste management has not

are also smaller community-led MRFs in Chullyu and Gobuk in Upper Siang.

Here, 12 full-time MRF operators and dozens of women from self-help groups perform the secondary sorting, into 35 categories.

The locals also wash and dry sanitary napkins and diapers, which are also stored at MRFs. More than 20 tonnes have been sold to recyclers, generating a revenue of ₹3.53 lakh.



Villagers gather during a waste-collection drive in Taksang, Zemithang Circle, Tawang District. Taksang is 11,000 feet above the sea level. FURTHER AND BEYOND FOUNDATION/SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

non-biodegradable waste. They store it in their homes. And then once a month, the community comes together and segregates the waste on a ‘collection day’,” Tashi Dondhup, additional deputy commissioner, Lumla Circle, which adopted the model as well, said.

“We don’t have any sanitation workers. Every village organises a collection day called *Swachchata Divas* (Cleanliness Day),” Ms. Zibrani said. A designated location in the village becomes the collection and sorting point, where “residents gather with sacks full of waste, and sort it into 22 categories. Some even clean the streets along the way.”

So far, 26 villages that are part of the project have organised more than 150 *Swachchata Divas* and collected 30 tonnes of waste. The waste is taken to material recovery facilities (MRF), sites in Zemithang, Lumla and Daporijo where it is received, sorted, and processed. There

Monthly fee

Per the UNEP, the most expensive step in the waste management chain is collection: in the form of crew wages, vehicle fuel and maintenance, insurance, and other indirect costs. A recent CSE report on plastic waste management, which Mr. Singh co-authored, also found that primary collection and transportation account for the bulk of costs in Indian cities.

The report examined the case of rural Dharamshala, where nearly 50% of the primary collection cost was attributed to manpower.

The Himalayan Fringes Project eliminated the costs associated with sanitation workers and door-to-door collection. And to keep the operations financially sustainable, the community has set up accountability and independent financing mechanisms. Specifically, each region has a central

committee chaired by a Circle Officer and a Lama (an influential religious leader) as secretary. At the village level, a *gaon bura* (village head) and a treasurer lead the committees that draft waste management policies, and set the rules, responsibilities, and fines. They meet every quarter.

Households are asked to pay a monthly fee of ₹50. Shops and cafes pay ₹100.

“Money is the biggest problem to run such a system,” Deewan Mara, former Zemithang Circle Officer, now officer and district magistrate, Daporijo, and a State Silver Medal winner for his work on managing waste, said.

First and last mile

Majuli’s 1.67 lakh people are served by 37 sanitation workers and 19 sorting staff.

Mridul Das, 38, from Silakola is one of them. Most people segregate their waste, he said. “But in every 100 households there may be 30 who still give mixed waste. They don’t listen.”

Recently, Mr. Gogoi’s department and the Panchayat and Rural Development Department purchased 21 e-vehicles – including the one Mr. Das drives – and 15 tricycles, and approved funds for the collection crew.

The transportation cost to recyclers is high in rural areas because the waste travels farther, Mr. Singh said, rendering the task less attractive for scrap dealers.

Ms. Zibrani said it costs ₹45,000 to send one truckload of waste from Arunachal Pradesh to Assam. Initially, the locals in Tawang volunteered their vehicles for collection. But over time, the project’s success drew the attention of Senior State government officials, who donated a truck. Yet the cost of fuel and driver is still Rs 20,000 per trip, she added. Apart from this, some two tonnes of multi-layered plastics were sent to a processing plant at Lhou in Jang sub-division, where it was used to make paver blocks, Mr. Dondhup said.

‘Show a way’

Between April 2025 and May 2026, Majuli transferred 16.78 tonnes of waste and earned ₹1.47 lakh. Mr. Bormedhi said there have been three boat transfers, which are expensive, so now Majuli sells its waste to local scrap dealers as well.

However, there have been no takers for black polythene and textile scrap, and Majuli’s long-defunct plastics management facility is undergoing repairs. Many CMCFs are also filling up quickly.

According to Mr. Singh, it is not uncommon to find rural collection facilities filled to the brim with baled waste, and with few takers. Mr. Bormedhi is not discouraged, however. Since 2024, Majuli has collected 82.4 tonnes of waste and thus prevented it from ending up in the Brahmaputra and the ocean, he said.

“All we are trying to do is to show a way. A model where rural waste management can work.”

Mahima Jain is a resident fellow at the Climate Change Media Hub, Asian College of Journalism. (mhmajain@gmail.com)



NASA astronaut evaluates the AstroRad vest onboard the International Space Station in 2022. 2S0CKZ (CC BY-SA)

AstroRad vest offers lighter shield against solar storms

Vasudevan Mukunth

Despite their best efforts to settle the moon and later Mars, humans may never become a spacefaring species, more than a few experts have said over the years. An important reason for this view is radiation. The earth has a magnetic field that keeps harmful radiation at bay, but astronauts who fly beyond this field are at risk of developing cancer and other serious health problems.

A common fix for this problem has been to add more shielding for astronauts. However, every additional kilogram increases the launch cost by a large amount, and it is often also impractical to add enough shielding to a crew capsule to cope with a major outburst of radiation from the sun.

To this end, an Israeli company named StemRad has, along with Lockheed Martin, developed a vest called AstroRad. StemRad had originally made the suit for emergency responders on the ground

Radiation remains a major obstacle to long duration human spaceflight because astronauts beyond earth’s magnetic field face increased risks of cancer and other health problems

who may be exposed to nuclear radiation. The company adapted it for spaceflight, with a twist: AstroRad has more safeguards over the chest, abdomen, and pelvis, where there are large amounts of bone marrow, which make blood, and sensitive organs like the heart and the lungs. It also uses hydrogen-rich polymers to block radiation – materials rich in hydrogen slow energetic particles efficiently because hydrogen nuclei are similar in mass and so maximise energy transfer during collisions – rather than lead, which is more dense.

In 2019 and 2020, NASA arranged for astronauts to test AstroRad onboard the International Space Station. They wore it as they performed ordinary activities and gave feedback on its comfort and functionalities, allowing engineers on the ground to make improvements.

NASA tested the improved version onboard its Artemis I mission in 2022. In this mission, the crew capsule carried two human-shaped dummies named Helga and Zohar as it travelled around the moon before returning to the earth. Both Helga and Zohar were fit with materials designed to mimic human tissue as well as radiation sensors. Zohar wrote AstroRad while Helga did not.

The results of analysing the data retrieved from the dummies were published in *Science Advances* on August 12. Using data collected during Artemis I to inform models of historical solar radiation events, researchers – from StemRad, Lockheed, the German, Israeli, and U.S. space agencies, and institutions in the U.S. – found AstroRad could reduce the effective radiation dose an astronaut would have received during the August 1972 solar storm by 60% and during the October 1989 solar storm by 40%. These amount to 193 and 131 fewer days, respectively of exposure to deep-space radiation.

Per the team, for astronauts heading back to the moon and eventually to Mars, AstroRad could allow astronauts to partially work through a solar storm instead of having to shelter themselves for the duration – a small but important step towards making interplanetary human spaceflight a safe reality.

That said, one particular shortcoming of the vest is that it can only deal with particles from the sun. Galactic cosmic rays that originate beyond the solar system remain harder to block.

For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Daily page’



While this shows a working regulatory system, the expansion led by the private sector is of additional concern as it is accompanied by incentives for these institutions to maximise student intake while maintaining faculty size and laboratory infrastructure. As of August 21, the NCISM had listed 17 Ayurveda colleges – all private – whose permissions it had denied, several for “non-compliance with inspection process”. In *Hillside Ayurveda Medical College* (2023), the Karnataka High Court acknowledged that often educational institutions are ... guilty of admitting excess students for financial gains”. The National Commission for Homoeopathy has given 41% of all homoeopathy colleges the lowest grade, including nearly half of all private institutions. Effectively, the expansion of AYUSH education is amid persistent quality issues, including inadequate or disputed faculty strengths, failures in inspection requirements and student intake numbers, and even allegations of fictitious faculty. While it would be premature to infer that the rapid expansion evident will have amplified these problems, the persistent regulatory non-compliance warrants tougher quality control and a reexamination of the incentives for private institutions, together with questions about the evidence backing AYUSH medicinal systems.

India's power infrastructure is emerging as a big threat to vultures

Whereas for many decades the chief concern about vulture safety was centered on chemical threats, the threat of electrocution posed by India's expanding power infrastructure may supersede it. In the 1990s, India's vultures suffered one of the world's worst population crashes, nosediving 99.5% by 2007 from a high of around four crore in the 1980s; the white-rumped, Indian, and slender-billed vultures were nearly wiped out. The culprit was diclofenac, a painkiller for cattle that wrecks vulture kidneys. The government banned the use of diclofenac, with additional bans in 2023 to mitigate threats posed by aceclofenac and ketoprofen, among some other NSAIDs. The birds' decline left carcasses exposed for longer, supporting feral dog populations and leading to rabies outbreaks; a 2024 study in American Economic Review estimated that human mortality thus rose 4% and the associated damages cost India \$69.4 billion a year. While electrocution has not become as deadly as NSAIDs have been, the fragility of the vulture population and the proliferation of unsafe power infrastructure warrant early action. One official survey reported in 2025 that vultures were nesting at only 50% of their historic nesting sites. It is no trivial detail that the raptors' wide wingspans mean a large individual can contact two conductors at once. They also have a habit of perching on elevated structures, are attracted to open landscapes, and have incentives to congregate where the availability of food is predictable, a risk enhanced by people dumping food waste around electrical installations.

As *The Hindu* reported based on a recent study in the *Journal of Threatened Taxa*, "relocating a livestock carcass dump 2.4 km away from high-tension power infrastructure near Uttarakhand's Dehradun may have saved these large scavengers from ... electrocution". An assessment prepared for the State Climate Resilient Power System Development Project also noted an Egyptian vulture and some steppe eagles had been electrocuted on medium-voltage, rather than high-voltage, lines. Research has noted that persistent mortality due to electrocution alone could render a local population extinct. Avian electrocution is also likely under-documented in India since dead birds can be removed by humans or scavenged. As the study indicated, one inexpensive solution is to separate vulture feeding sites from power infrastructure. Other measures to protect raptors, and even other birds, especially near settlements, include insulating conductors, increasing the gap between energised and grounded components or otherwise preventing a bird from bridging them – non-trivial considering vulture wingspans – and installing safe perches.

While the global population will continue to grow for some time, that growth is uneven across political boundaries and social groups. India itself is moving rapidly through a fertility transition. India's total fertility rate has fallen below replacement level, to 2.0 children per woman



The reason for continued population growth in many societies is increasingly expanding lifespan and population momentum rather than increasing births. The spread of that growth is uneven across political boundaries and social groups. Similarly, wealth creation and distribution remain uneven and will remain so. Fewer people are being born, people are living longer, moving faster and farther; these factors in combination with demands of democracy and federalism raise challenges that require cool thinking and new imaginative capacity.

Politics must move from profiting from demographic change to sensitively managing and navigating its consequences

K.B. Usha
Associate Professor,
School of
International Studies,
Jawaharlal Nehru
University, New Delhi

Unlike other thinkers of non-violence, Miniotaité regarded Gandhi as the most successful in both theory and practice, demonstrating that non-violent struggle could

World over, conversations about demographic shifts have become a source of diatribe. While one group talks about replacement theory and fears that its race is being wiped out, another dismisses such concerns as conspiracy theories. Demographic change is neither a conspiracy to replace any community nor an imagined phenomenon. It is real, natural, and likely to be difficult to reverse. Politics needs to shift from trying to profit from demographic change to sensitively managing and navigating it. The question, then, is whether there can be a more expansive idea of “The People.”

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A turning point

The Singing Revolution (1986-91), shaped by songs and non-violence during Mikhail Gorbachev's perestroika and glasnost, reached a turning point with the Baltic Way, when two million people formed a 675-kilometre human chain from Tallinn through Riga to Vilnius, demanding freedom from Soviet rule. It remains a powerful symbol of unity, solidarity, and freedom. The Baltic Way was organised on the 50th anniversary of the 1939 Molotov-Ribbentrop Pact to expose its secret protocol, which divided Eastern Europe into German and Soviet spheres of influence, and paved the way for the Soviet annexation of the Baltic states in 1940. Having gained independence in 1918, the Baltics lost it after 22 years. The Baltic Way exposed Soviet-era repression, leading to the Soviet Union's acknowledgement of the secret protocol's existence and the Baltic states' re-independence in 1991. Its global media coverage drew international attention, while its inscription in

The Mahatma's principles of non-violence have forged enduring bonds between the Baltics and India

Turning to science
The tragedy in Nepal is heartbreaking with the loss of many lives and displacement of many. The Himalayas are home to massive glaciers and experts now warn that regions closer to India could face similar avalanches. Instead of waiting for the

next calamity, should not governments invest in research for preventive action? For instance, exploring scientific methods to safely scatter unstable ice masses before they collapse naturally? If science can contemplate diverting asteroids in space, surely we can find a solution for a

threat whose location and magnitude are well known to us. This could be taken up as a global project under the United Nations, with all nations contributing funds and expertise to save humanity from such disasters.

B.C. Ramani,
Hyderabad

Trees felled in one swoop
There is increasing felling of trees in the name of development. Roads, highways, buildings and other construction projects are expanding rapidly, but unfortunately, thousands of trees are being cut down. Development is necessary for progress, but it should

not come at the cost of our environment. Trees provide oxygen, reduce air pollution, regulate temperatures and help maintain ecological balance. Their large-scale removal contributes to rising temperatures, air pollution, soil erosion and the loss of wildlife habitats. Authorities should adopt

development plans that minimise tree loss. Wherever trees must be removed, they should be replaced through proper plantation drives.

Vandit Jain,
Chandigarh

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

The battle within the BJP in Bengal

One hundred days after the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) ended 15 years of Trinamool Congress rule in West Bengal, a consequential battle is unfolding in the State within the BJP itself.

By taking oath as Bengal's first BJP Chief Minister, Suwendu Adhikari inherited a State that had voted for rapture. Voters rejected extortion, strongmen, patronage, unreliable employment, and the migration of young Bengalis. The mandate carried special weight for the BJP, and the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) which had spent decades building an organisation in the State when electoral power seemed distant.

Yet Bengal has changed political colour faster than political culture. Trinamool offices, auto and e-rickshaw stands once controlled by Trinamool workers now carry BJP flags; strongmen who once stood beside Trinamool legislators now appear beside BJP leaders. The contradiction is stark: Mr. Adhikari who promised to dismantle Mamata Banerjee's political system, is consolidating power by absorbing the very same system and networks.

This has created a contest between three forces within the party: the Sangh, seeking ideological continuity; Samik Bhattacharya, the State BJP president, seeking restraint; and Mr. Adhikari, whose instincts were shaped inside the Trinamool.

Three-pronged battle
The RSS's concern is rooted in memory and sacrifice. Its cadres spent decades building the BJP in Bengal, amid violence and isolation. For them, victory was



Sayantan Ghosh
teaches at St. Xavier's College (Autonomous), Kolkata, and is the author of 'Battleground Bengal' and 'The Aam Aadmi Party'

supposed to begin a different political culture.

However, the Chief Minister sees Bengal differently. Power does not reside only in the Assembly or secretariat but in clubs, booths, contractors, transport networks, and strongmen. Bengal has repeatedly shown that while political personnel can change parties, networks survive: Congress moved to the Left, the Left to Trinamool, and now sections of that ecosystem are moving to the BJP. This is where political scientist Dwaipayan Bhattacharya's concept of "party society" becomes crucial – in Bengal, the political party has historically become the principal mediator between citizens, institutions and the State. The CM understands this; his strategy is not to destroy the party society but to inherit it as it consolidates power the fastest.

Mr. Bhattacharya has tried to draw boundaries. He warned cadres against extortion, indiscipline, and misuse of the BJP's name. The party has expelled more than 30 leaders and suspended around 250 over allegations involving corruption, extortion, and anti-party activity. But victory's political energy is fast outrunning organisational restraint.

The contradiction is sharper in the BJP's handling of the Trinamool Congress. While the party says its doors are closed, three former Trinamool Rajya Sabha members have joined the BJP and received nominations immediately. In Parliament, around 20 rebel Trinamool MPs have merged with the Nationalist Citizen Party of India, which in turn, is desperate to merge with the BJP, making claims of

distance difficult to sustain.

Mr. Adhikari's play here is strategic as Ms. Banerjee cannot rebuild her organisation if her leaders are absorbed and networks are transferred. For the RSS, however, the harder question is whether absorbing Trinamool networks also means absorbing their habits. Grassroots workers are unsettled; BJP cadres now see former adversaries accommodated as *Bhalo Trinamool* (good Trinamool). For those who lost homes, livelihoods, and family members during the Trinamool rule, rehabilitation can look like betrayal.

Disrupter or custodian?
A party can absorb individuals without becoming the party they came from. However, inheriting its methods, networks, and political instincts is different.

These 100 days are more than a report card on Mr. Adhikari's government. They mark an argument over what the Bengal BJP will become. For the Sangh, victory vindicated decades of work. For Mr. Bhattacharya, it was supposed to create a disciplined alternative. For the CM, the priority is ensuring that the Trinamool cannot recover. All three can coexist for now. They may not coexist forever.

The danger is that, in seeking permanence rather than merely victory, the BJP may preserve, instead of disrupt, the political system that made the Trinamool powerful. Bengal has changed its government; the harder question is whether the BJP will change the system it inherited or simply become its new custodian.

The need for political unity in Kashmir

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah descended onto New Delhi's streets, in July, with his Cabinet in tow to press for restoration of J&K's federal guarantees – he was denied permission to protest at the emblematic Jantar Mantar. The Peoples Democratic Party chief Mehbooba Mufti, and Srinagar MP Ruhullah Mehdi spearheaded separate programmes in Delhi in the following days. If one had expected this line up of events in the capital to be a surreal moment of reclaiming Kashmir's democratic space for dissent, one was not enthused. What was more prominently illustrated was the deep divisions within the Kashmiri leadership.

After Omar Abdullah came to power in October 2024, he prudently focused on repairing ties with New Delhi. He had hoped that a calibrated navigation would be helpful in negotiating a respectable arrangement for J&K. But in Srinagar, Mr. Abdullah's political opponents described his exploration of areas of agreement with New Delhi and the tailored camaraderie it entailed, as pusillanimous. They iterated that there couldn't be a lesser political goal post in Kashmir than reversing the August 5, 2019 legislations that stripped the Himalayan region of its semi-autonomous status.

While Kashmir's right to dignity and respectable federal arrangement is non-negotiable, the way to realising it cannot be the daily whipping of a rather disempowered local government for not being combative enough. Though this resentment is received



Anando Bhakto
New Delhi-based senior journalist reporting on Kashmir developments

well in the echo canyons of people's online lives, it serves no other purpose except to create a veneer of ideological supremacy for a few. The need of the hour for all of Gupkar's politicians is to contemplate political unity even when grave disagreement simmers beneath the surface. The importance of political unity cannot be overlooked at a time when rest of India's Opposition is palpably wary of involving itself in the Kashmir question.

Nearly two years after the electorate turned out in impressive numbers to elect a local Government and upend the "bureaucratic apparatus" that had settled snugly in its absence, the unelected office of the Lieutenant Governor (LG) continues to wield significant power, heightening confusion. In a region with proximity to violence, it may express itself in a spatter of political dismissiveness: not just of the local government but of participatory democracy itself.

Ensuring Kashmiri participation in elections has always been tricky. It is often the outcome of mainstream leaders' penetrating patronage networks. Rural belts vote more briskly because people have dependence on local politicians, for amenities, and as protective shields against police arbitrariness.

Case studies of several Public Safety Act detainees underscored that local legislators are often the "go to" persons for political and legal support, a favour paid off with the ballot even when one may not be otherwise upbeat about elections. The bureaucratic apparatus created a vacuum which people voted to reverse.

While Kashmir's right to dignity and respectable federal arrangement is non-negotiable, the way to realising it cannot be the daily whipping of a rather disempowered local government for not being combative enough

V-dem's democracy index rates India at its lowest since 1975

The UN CERD's concerns about the exclusion of a large number of voters is in line with the V-Dem Institute's data on India's democratic backslide

DATA POINT

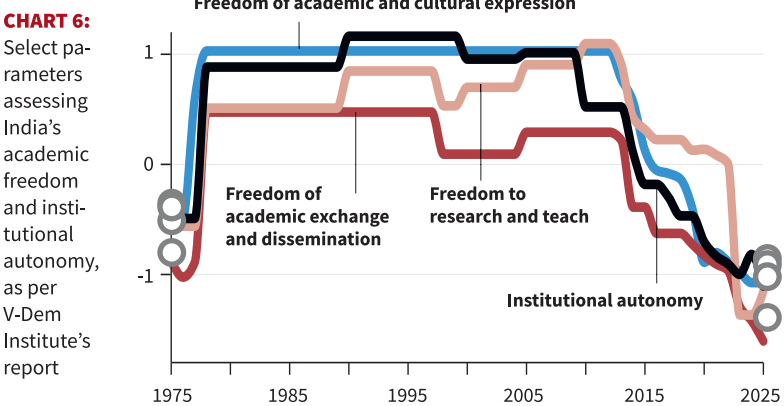
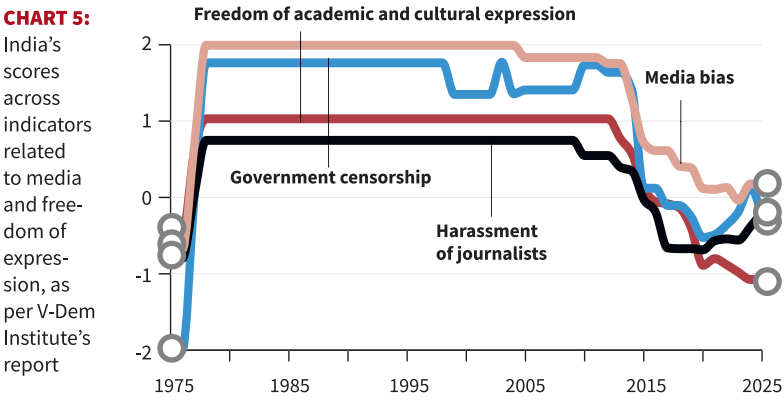
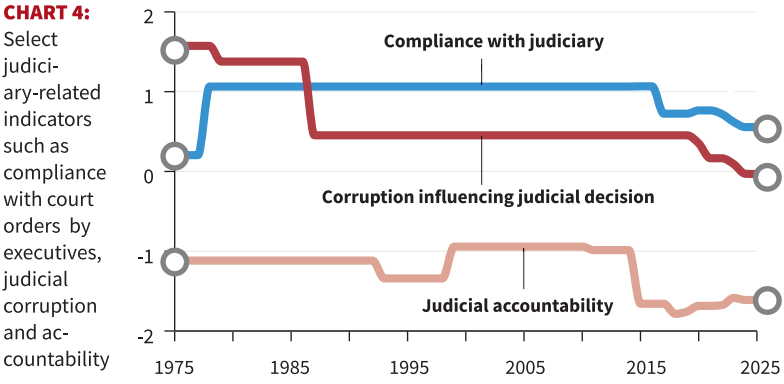
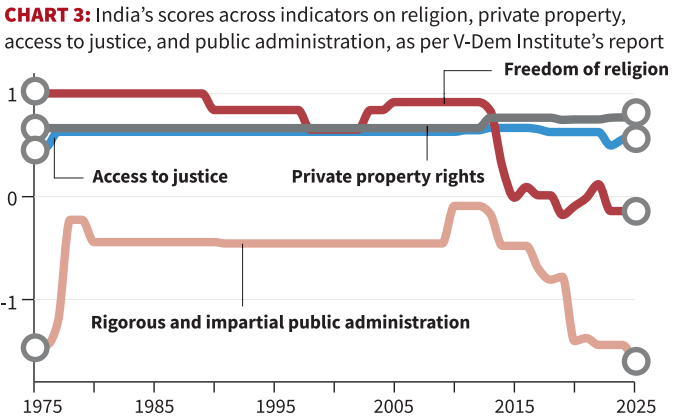
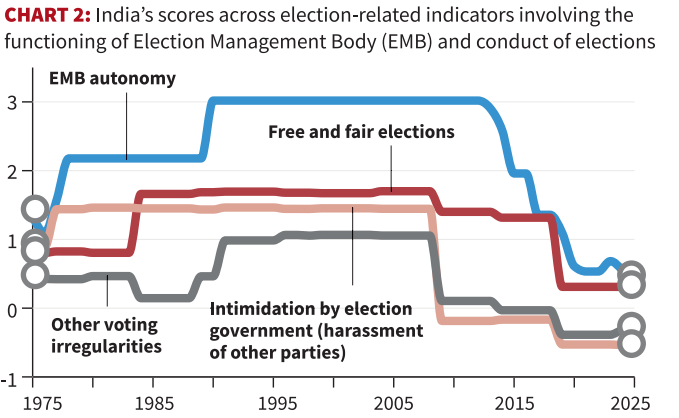
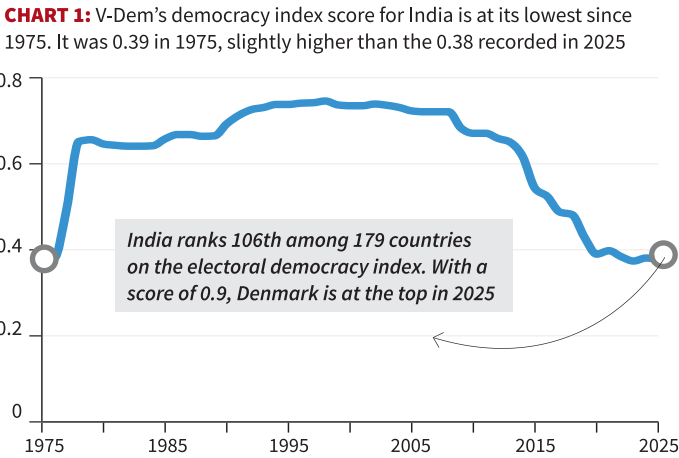
Sambavi Parthasarathy
Gauri Singavarapu

Last week, the UN Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination (CERD), said it was "gravely concerned" about "reports of large-scale violations perpetrated by law enforcement officials" in its first review of India since 2007. The committees' observations included concerns over the exclusion of large number of voters, Muslims in particular, as part of the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls. UN CERD's criticism seems to be in line with some of the observations in the latest democracy report by the University of Gothenburg-based Varieties of Democracy (V-Dem) Institute, which uses a multidimensional approach to "conceptualising and measuring democracy." It noted India as one of the countries that is "autocratising" slowly with a systematic dismantling of democratic institutions. This is reflected in the institute's electoral democracy index released in March. While India's performance has gradually declined since 2009, the latest index score is India's lowest since 1975, when the country was under Emergency rule (**Chart 1**). India's scores across parameters such as judicial accountability and corruption, autonomy of the Election Management Body (EMB), and impartial administration by public officials are at their lowest in 50 years. (**Charts 2, 3, 4**).

The decline in autonomy of institutions, as per the report, seems to have accompanied deteriorations in freedom of academic and cultural expression and harassment of journalists (**Chart 5**). Academic freedom measured through indicators such as freedom of academic expression, freedom to research and teach, and institutional autonomy have also declined (**Chart 6**).

New depths

The data for the charts were sourced from the Varieties of Democracy (V-Dem) Institute, University of Gothenburg, Sweden. Gauri Singavarapu is interning with The Hindu's Data team



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The **Hindu.**

FIFTY YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 1, 1976

Efforts to improve life of Sikkim Lepchas

Gangtok, August 31: The original inhabitants of Sikkim, the Lepchas, who to-day constitute a mere 15 per cent of the State's total population, have a special reason to be happy now. For the first time a detailed land survey has started in their area known as Dzongu in North Sikkim, as a major step towards effective implementation of land reforms in the State.

The backward people of Dzongu do not have any proper records of their rights and lands. For long this place has been considered as the property of the former royal family and the poor Lepchas have been exploited by them for decades. Dzongu being in the extreme north of the State has no easy communication with the outside world and so the people have yet to know the world outside. Very few of them can be seen even in the capital of Gangtok.

Most of the earnings of these families are spent on eating and drinking, of which they are extremely fond. Oldtimers in the capital even to-day recall incidents of these people coming here to sell their produce, mainly cardamom, and being satisfied with the liquor served to them by the business community as consideration for their produce.

At a recently organised meeting at Tingbhum in Dzongu, a group of the community elders, passed a resolution favouring drastic changes in their way of life, especially in regard to expenses on marriage.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 1, 1926

Marconi's new invention

An "Englishman" cable from London, dated August 29 states:-
Signor Marconi has successfully experimented with a special loud speaker giving great amplification with enlarged batteries which magnify sounds without sacrificing quality. He believes they can be developed until the voice carries twenty miles. He is leaving for Italy in his yacht the "Electra" on September 1 and will carry out a series of experiments to determine the strength of the beams operating between England and Canada and England and South Africa in order to increase the efficiency of long distance transmission and prevent countries for which they are not intended receiving the waves.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Amount outlined for Semicon programme by government

1.27 in ₹ lakh crore. The government on Monday notified the ₹1.27-lakh-crore Semicon 2.0 programme, spelling out eligibility and incentives across the semiconductor value chain, including 40% fiscal support for silicon wafer fabs with a minimum investment of ₹20,000 crore, and sweeteners for chip design. PTI

Surplus liquidity in banking system at the end of August

5 in ₹ lakh crore. Surplus liquidity in the banking system surged to nearly ₹5 lakh crore at the end of August, its highest level in over four months, boosted by month-end government spending and robust foreign currency deposits. According to data compiled by PTI from the Reserve Bank of India, surplus system liquidity stood at ₹5.05 lakh crore as on August 30. PTI

Monthly stipend of medical interns in J&K that triggered strikes

12,300 in ₹ MBBS and BDS interns across medical colleges in Jammu and Kashmir went on an indefinite strike on Monday, protesting a monthly stipend of just ₹12,300 and demanding it be raised to 30,000. The protesting interns claimed that their stipend had remained unchanged for nearly seven years. PTI

Number of houses sanctioned by A.P. under PMAY-Urban 2.0

17,912 The Andhra Pradesh government on Monday sanctioned nearly 18,000 houses at a cost of about ₹448 crore under the PMAY-Urban 2.0. An official said the unit cost of each house is ₹2.5 lakh, of which 60% will be provided as assistance by the Centre and the remaining 40% by the State government. PTI

Value of Israel's defence export deal with Greece

3.5 in \$ billion. Israel signed a multi-billion-dollar weapons deal with Greece, as Israeli defence exports soar. Israel's Defence Ministry said the nearly €3 billion (\$3.5 billion) defence export deal, coined Achilles Shield, is one of the country's largest and includes a multilayered air defence system for Greece using Israeli technology. AP

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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The broken promise of right to work

The replacement of MGNREGA with the VB-GRAM G Act has weakened the rural right-to-work framework; restoring a meaningful right to work through adequate funding, living wages and stronger local institutions would advance constitutional aims while also supporting rural demand and economic growth

ECONOMIC NOTES

Rajendran Narayanan
Vijay Ram S.

In August 21, a three-judge Supreme Court Bench led by the Chief Justice of India dismissed a petition and sought a fresh one in a case on minimum wages in rural employment guarantee programmes. The Bench lauded MGNREGA's role in rural development. It probed whether the 'Right to Work' should be treated on par with Article 21, the fundamental right to life, sparking an important discussion on the constitutional foundations of this right.

A guarantee under strain
Despite its limited scope of only 100 days of work per rural household and chronic underfunding, the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA) was the only law anchored in the core principle of the right to work. In December 2025, the Union government replaced MGNREGA with the Viksit Bharat – Guarantee for Rozgar & Aajeevika Mission (Gramin) (VB-GRAM G) Act, and its implementation began on July 1. About 3.44 crore households worked for about 44 crore person-days under MGNREGA in July and August, on average, over the previous five years (**Table 1**). There has been a 68% decrease in employment in July and August this year compared with the average of the preceding five years. Notwithstanding the proverbial 'teething issues', the dismantling of MGNREGA's demand-driven right-to-work framework and the disproportionate fiscal burden that the new law places on States are likely to be major factors behind the dramatic fall in employment under the VB-GRAM G Act.

The impact of taking away even this limited right to work is therefore palpable. Discussions around the recent Supreme Court observations on the right to work can be traced back to the Constituent Assembly debates.

While most members agreed that a right to work was vital, the debate rested on whether it should be a fundamental right or be part of the Directive Principles of State Policy (DPSP). The DPSPs do not automatically constitute rights but are meant to serve as precepts for governments to formulate laws and policies. This became the basis of the differences in perspective.

Professor K.T. Shah had strongly advocated recognising the right to work as a fundamental right, arguing that the State needed a constitutional and positive legal mandate to guarantee socio-economic security to its citizens. Dr. B.R. Ambedkar, among others, held that while the right to work was an essential goal, its immediate universal enforcement was not fiscally and institutionally viable in a newly independent India that had been hollowed out of its resources. The placement of the right within the Directive Principles, rather than among the fundamental rights, thus reflected a deliberate constitutionalism of aspiration, rather than an abandonment of the welfare ideal. As scholars Anjani Kapoor and Manu Bhagwan have written in their essay 'Ambedkar and the anti-isolation of Fellowship', "The constitution does not establish the nation, but rather provides the tools to help achieve it."

Therefore, Article 41 of the DPSP states: "The State shall, within the limits of its economic capacity and development,

A shrinking safety net

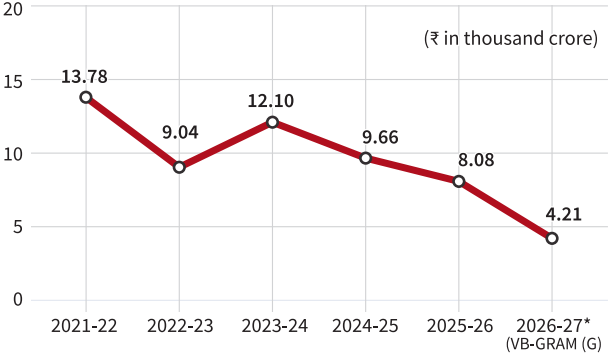
The shift from MGNREGA to VB-GRAM G has sharply reduced rural employment and earnings

Table 1: The number of households (HH) employed, persondays of work generated and average daily wages paid in July and August

Financial year	HH provided employment (in crore)	Persondays of work generated (in crore)	Average daily wage paid in July & August (₹)
2021-22	4.79	65.74	210
2022-23	3.13	40.14	225.5
2023-24	3.82	49.13	246.5
2024-25	3.04	37.36	259
2025-26	2.44	29.78	272
2026-27* (VB-GRAM G)	1.39	14.94	282.5

Sources: MGNREGA and VB-GRAM G MIS reports.
*Data as on 31st August 2026 for FY 2026-27.

Figure 1: Estimated household earnings in July and August



*Data as on 31st Aug 2026 | Note: Total household earnings = sum of average wage rate paid x persondays of work generated in July and August

Sources: MGNREGA and VB-GRAM G MIS reports.



make effective provision for securing the right to work..." Embodying stronger progressive consecrations, Articles 39, 42 and 43 call for the "right to an adequate means of livelihood, equal pay for equal work for both men and women, just and humane conditions of work" and to "secure to all workers a living wage and decent standard of life."

From aspiration to a statutory right
The Supreme Court, in *Olga Tellis vs Bombay Municipal Corporation* (1985), ruled that the right to livelihood was a necessary condition for the fundamental right to life, giving a judicial fillip to the right to work. Spurred by the collective efforts of activists and rural workers, the National Rural Employment Guarantee Act was passed in 2005. Although limited in scope, it made a pan-India right-to-work law a reality for the first time. The State had to ensure its statutory obligation to provide employment at minimum wages.

In 2009, MGNREGA wages were delinked from the Minimum Wages Act, 1948. Over time, MGNREGA wages barely kept pace with inflation and continued to remain lower than the minimum agricultural wages in most States. Low wages and an inadequate budget for generating employment have resulted in a steep decline in household earnings, with estimated total household earnings halving in July and August this year compared with the same months last year (**Figure 1**).

During the recent hearing, the Supreme Court Bench remarked that if financial resources remained the same, having a minimum wage threshold could reduce the number of workers who could

be provided employment. This remark, which appears to align with the Union government's approach to employment guarantee, merits scrutiny on at least two counts.

First, it vitiates the judgment in *Sanjit Roy vs State of Rajasthan* (1983) where the Supreme Court observed that payment of wages below minimum wages violates Article 23 of the Constitution and is akin to 'forced labour.' Second, it rests on a misleading economic logic that financial resources to implement a welfare programme must remain unchanged and constrained.

In reality, higher wages for rural workers increase their purchasing power, enhance their freedoms, and improve human development outcomes. These, in turn, increase effective demand for goods and services, creating a positive multiplier effect, resulting in higher economic productivity. Therefore, higher government spending on an employment guarantee programme at increased wages can yield a mutually reinforcing cycle between development and growth.

A retreat from the right to work
By putting an arbitrary cap on funds for the VB-GRAM G Act and not linking it with minimum wages, the very notion of employment guarantee stands delegitimised. States are already grappling with fiscal constraints and curtailed borrowing limits under the Fiscal Responsibility and Budget Management (FRBM) framework. The increased burden of funding the VB-GRAM G Act will prevent States from generating employment. The sharp drop in employment and earnings is a reflection of this change.

The VB-GRAM G Act also contains provisions to denotify certain areas and exclude them from the scheme, thereby limiting the universality of MGNREGA's right to work.

Lawyer Purbayan Chakraborty highlights how the Supreme Court has affirmed the doctrine of non-retrogression in *Navej Singh Johar vs Union of India*. The doctrine implies that once the State has achieved a certain level of progressive legislation and enforceability of a right, it cannot implement measures that deliberately undo it. Non-retrogression operates as a check on State power, ensuring that rights, once realised, are not diluted later. The replacement of MGNREGA with the VB-GRAM G Act appears to be in violation of this doctrine.

Rural wages have been stagnant for a decade, while women are increasingly employed as 'unpaid family workers'. In such light, the minimal requirements for affirming the commitment to the right to work are: linking MGNREGA wages to living wages, timely payment of wages, a focus on social audits by empowering local institutions to be partners in mitigating corruption, and giving more powers to Panchayati Raj institutions.

All these measures could be implemented within a legal framework of the right to work. The VB-GRAMG Act, unfortunately, is silent on most of them. Reinstating the right to work would therefore not only be a legal course correction advancing constitutional aims, but would also be sound economics. (The authors are affiliated with the Centre for the Study of the Indian Economy, Azim Premji University. The views expressed are personal)

THE GIST

▼ The Supreme Court's recent observations have revived the Constituent Assembly-era debate over whether the right to work should be a fundamental right or remain under the directive principles

▼ Keeping employment guarantee budgets constrained and wages below minimum wages can undermine both the constitutional promise of the right to work and rural household earnings

▼ Higher wages and greater public spending on employment can boost workers' purchasing power, stimulate demand for goods and services, and support wider economic growth

BUILDING BLOCKS



GETTY IMAGES

What goes on behind the screen when you pay through UPI?

UPI enables instant bank-to-bank payments by connecting users' apps and banks through a system operated by the National Payments Corporation of India; launched in 2016, it has grown into a massive digital payments network and is now being adopted in several countries

Vasudevan Mukunth

The Unified Payments Interface (UPI) is India's preeminent digital payments system. In July 2026 alone, it processed 2,366 crore transactions – or around 7,600 transactions per second – in total worth nearly ₹30 lakh crore. Across the 2025-26 financial year, UPI handled 24,160 crore transactions worth ₹314 lakh crore, accounting for 85% of the country's digital payment transactions by volume. According to the International Monetary Fund, UPI also accounted for a stunning 49% of all real-time payments worldwide in 2025.

How does UPI work?

Say Selvi has an account in Violin Bank and Shankar has an account in Flute Bank. Selvi wants to send Shankar ₹100 via UPI. First, Selvi tells her UPI app – which could be Google Pay, PhonePe, etc. – whom she wants to pay. Obviously the app will not understand who 'Shankar' is. Instead, she will have to tell the app in a language the app understands.

In this language, Shankar's identity has two parts: his unique name and his unique bank name. So it will be something like shankar@flutebank. This UPI ID will be connected to Shankar's bank account. In technical terms, the ID is an alias of the account.

So when Selvi tells her UPI app that she needs to send money to shankar@flutebank, the app will know which account the money should go to.

Second, the app will send a payment request to the UPI system. UPI is operated by the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI). It provides the switching and routing infrastructure that links the 730 or so participating banks, allowing users to transfer money between accounts at these banks.

The UPI system will respond to Selvi's app's request by asking Selvi to authenticate the transaction. This is like a confirmation: "Let me make sure you want this transaction to happen." Selvi will do this by entering her UPI PIN. Now the system will know she has signed off on it.

The third step is for the actual transaction to happen. Selvi's bank, which is Violin Bank, will check the transaction. This involves asking questions such as whether Selvi's account is valid, has enough money, if the request is authentic, if the transaction limit has been reached, and if the transaction shows any signs of fraudulent activity.

If the check passes all tests, Violin Bank will let the UPI system know that it is ready to execute the transaction.

Fourth, the UPI system will route the transaction to Flute Bank, which is Shankar's bank, and into the account associated with shankar@flutebank.

Fifth, Violink Bank will deduct ₹100 from Selvi's account and Flute Bank will add ₹100 to Shankar's account.

Sixth, and finally, Flute Bank will report the addition to the UPI system, which will then relay it to Violin Bank, and finally to the UPI app in Selvi's hand.

How complex is the system?

This simplified picture is essentially what the UPI system makes possible. However, it is not complete. The system has more technical components to ensure that different banks can trust each transaction, update records correctly, and be able to respond in a predictable way when a transaction goes awry.

For a glimpse, to connect to Violin Bank – from where Selvi initiated the transaction – the UPI app (Google Pay, PhonePe, etc.) will communicate with TPAP/PSP infrastructure, which allows apps to interact with banking services.

TPAP is a company that provides the app used to make UPI payments, e.g., PhonePe. And PSP is the bank or company that connects the app to the NPCI infrastructure.

For another, Violin Blank and Flute Bank will exchange multiple messages during the transaction, including to start payment, authenticate it, authorise it, confirm debit, confirm credit, and confirm status at each step.

And so on. On the hardware side, UPI requires thousands of servers, which process transactions, store and use databases, facilitate API calls, run monitoring and security systems; high-speed network switches and routers, which connect banks and data centres; and redundant servers, cooling systems, networking equipment, and of course power supplies.

On the software side, the system is made possible by APIs, transaction switches and routers, databases, message queues, encryption and authentication services, fraud detectors, reconciliation software, and disaster recovery protocols. The banks and the apps also have software to connect their systems with the NPCI infrastructure.

The UPI ID

The UPI ID, e.g., shankar@flutebank or selvi@violinbank, is created and maintained by the respective bank, based on a rule the bank has.

For example, if two account holders have the same name, their IDs can be distinguished by a number – selvi1@violinbank and selvi2@violinbank. Users may also be able to customise their UPI IDs, e.g. selvithestar@violinbank.

Fundamentally, the UPI app knows that the string before the '@' is the user account's alias and the string after the '@' is the bank's identity. The latter tells the UPI system which service will know

which account the former is an alias of.

An individual user can have multiple UPI IDs because their bank account can have multiple aliases. These aliases can also be encoded in QR codes.

UPI – past, present, future

The NPCI built the UPI system with entrepreneur and Infosys co-founder Nandan Nilekani as an advisor and with the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) providing regulatory guidance. Its foundation was as an interoperable layer over the Immediate Payment Service (IMPS), which is a system to quickly transfer funds from one bank to another round the clock.

Then RBI Governor Raghuram Rajan piloted UPI in April 2016 with 21 banks, with the service also becoming available via the banks' apps a couple months later. UPI 2.0 followed in mid-2018 with new features like linking overdraft accounts, adding mandates (authorising periodic transactions into the future), verifying invoices before payment, signed QR codes (to better verify merchants before transactions), and enhanced autopayments.

The UPI system crossed 100 crore transactions per month in October 2019. NPCI International Payments, Ltd. (NIPL) is a wholly owned subsidiary of the NPCI whose job is to facilitate international adoption of India's digital payments systems, especially UPI.

In 2021, NIPL and the Royal Monetary Authority of Bhutan enabled UPI in the kingdom – the first foreign adoption. Then, Singapore followed in 2021, the UAE in 2022, France, Mauritius, Sri Lanka, and Nepal in 2024, Qatar in 2025, and Cambodia, Greece, and the Maldives so far in 2026.

NIPL is reportedly also working on making UPI interoperable with the payment systems of Indonesia, Malaysia, and Thailand.

THE DAILY QUIZ

August 31 happens to be the birthday of former Philippine president Ramon Magsaysay. Here is a quiz on Indian Magsaysay Award winners

Srinivasan Ramani

QUESTION 1

Who was the first Indian to win the Magsaysay Award as early as 1958?

QUESTION 2

Who won the award in 1965 for public service? What was the title that he was known by?

QUESTION 3

Name the Indian who won the award in 1974. Apart from her primary area of expertise, she also acted in films in her youth. Name the last and most prominent film featuring her?

QUESTION 4

Another award winner in 2005, this person was born into a family that had two distinguished Nobel laureates. She served as a leading doctor and director of the Cancer Institute in Chennai for a number of years. Name her.

QUESTION 5

A former IAS officer, this awardee led major campaigns, the most prominent of which was the National Campaign for the People's Right to Information, which culminated in the Right to Information Act being passed in 2005. Name her.



Visual Question:

Identify this awardee. Cited for "guiding the people of [Andhra Pradesh] to end the scourge of child labour and send all of their children to school". WIKIPEDIA

Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz: 1. Malaysians celebrate 'Hari Merdeka' on August 31 to commemorate the independence of the Federation of Malaya from British rule. On what date do they celebrate Malaysia Day, which marks the formation of Malaysia? **Ans: September 16**
2. What is the monarch, who is elected from nine hereditary Malay Rulers for a five-year term, called, and who is the present ruler? **Ans: Yang di-Pertuan Agong and Sultan Ibrahim**
3. Whose portrait is featured on the Malaysian Ringgit? **Ans: Tuanku Abdul Rahman (the first Yang di-Pertuan Agong)**
4. Name the famous archipelago with 99 islands and geological formations that became Malaysia's first UNESCO Global Geopark. **Ans: Langkawi**
5. Name the Malaysian-born actress who became the first Asian woman to win the Best Actress Oscar in 2023. **Ans: Michelle Yeoh for her role in 'Everything Everywhere All at Once'**
6. In which sport did Nicol David win a record eight World Open titles? **Ans: Squash**
7. Which Bornean primate is known for its large, pendulous nose in males? **Ans: The proboscis monkey**
Visual: Name the place where this famous statue of Lord Muruga is located. **Ans: Batu Caves on the outskirts of Kuala Lumpur**
Early Birds: C. Saravanan | Mohan Lal Patel | Erfanally Oosmany | Tito Shiladitya | Prodosh Mitra



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

"You haven't finished reading that article yet?"

"Give me a couple of minutes, will you? Tell me, how do you pronounce p.r.e.c.o.u.s.i.o.u.s?"

"Has that word been used in the article?"

"You bet. The author has used it several times."

"I see. Well, the 'e' in the first syllable 'pre' is pronounced like the 'i' in 'sit', 'bit' and 'pit'; the following 'o' is like the 'o' in 'so', 'go' and 'no'."

"The final 'ious' is like the 'ious' in 'precious' and 'ambitious', I suppose?"

"Exactly! The 'c' in the second syllable is like the 'k' in 'kit', 'kin', and 'kiss', while..."

".... the final 'c' is like the 'sh' in 'ship', 'sheep', and 'sheet'. I had already guessed that. But tell me, what does the word mean?"

"Why don't you try and figure it out? How does the author use the word?"

"Well, he says that Jennifer Capriati 'burst onto the world tennis scene as a precocious 14-year old'."

"So what do you think the author is trying to say?"

"That 14-year old Jennifer was very talented?"

"That's right! The word is normally used with children. When you say that a child is 'precocious' what you are implying is that he/she is very clever or talented at something. The kind of talent that you would expect to find in an adult, but certainly not in a child."

"In other words, the child is mature beyond his/her years. Is that what you are saying?"

"Well, I guess you could say that."

"Devayani had precocious talent for music and dance."

"Though as a five-year-old, Saritha displayed precocious talent for tennis, her parents refused to send her to coaching camps."

"Were you a precocious child?"

"Me? You must be joking. I don't think anyone in my family was precocious."

"Didn't you say that your cousin Suresh was precocious? I remember you...."

"...I definitely didn't say that."

"But you said that he was a wonderful pilot. And I also think...."

"I probably said that he is rash. He is one of those who flies by the seat of his pants."

"Flies by the seat of his pants?"

"When you say that someone is doing something by the seat of his pants, what you are implying is that he is doing something instinctively. He is not doing things according to any well thought out plan."

"No thinking involved, eh? Then, can I say, our Chief Minister has no clue what he is doing. He is flying by the seat of his pants."

"I don't think so. You see, our poor Chief Minister is not doing anything, actually. He is merely a mouthpiece for somebody else. Somebody else is running the State for him. Try this example. The electrician that the company sent had no clue what he was doing. He was merely flying by the seat of his pants."

"Most traders don't know what is happening in the stock market. Many of them are flying by the seat of their pants."

"The expression can also be used to mean, 'by sheer luck and very little skill'. My cousin got through school by the seat of his pants."

"If I get through, it will probably be by the seat of my pants."

Published in The Hindu on October 23, 2001

Word of the day

Tact:

consideration in dealing with others and avoiding giving offence.

Synonyms: diplomacy, manners, courtesy, respect

Usage: She handled the sensitive issue with great tact.

Pronunciation: newsth.live/tact

International Phonetic Alphabet: /tækt/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'

INBRIEF



Mahindra Aerostructures to make A320 fuselage skins

Airbus has awarded a contract to Mahindra Aerostructures to manufacture and supply fuselage skins for covering the rear fuselage and tail sections of the Airbus A320neo and A321XLR aircraft under a multi-year programme with delivery targeted for 2028. The components will be manufactured at Mahindra Aerostructures’ facility in Bengaluru and supplied to Airbus’ manufacturing facility in Augsburg, Germany.

ISP shows 8 sub-sectors posted double-digit growth in June

The index of services production released on Monday for the third time on a trial basis showed eight of 19 service categories recorded double-digit growth in June this year. The statistics ministry released the Index of Services Production (ISP) for the month of June 2026 in respect of 19 sub-sectors, with base year 2024-25. Except for air transport, all categories recorded positive growth in June on an annual basis, a statement by the statistics ministry said.

Avantel bags ₹118 crore contract from DRDO

Technology solutions provider for defence and communication sectors Avantel has secured a contract for ₹17.88 crore from DRDO’s Defence Electronics Applications Laboratory (DEAL) for development, installation and commissioning of a Ground Segment Hub for voice and data communication using an Indian geostationary satellite. The order reflects confidence in its technological and execution capabilities, Avantel said. The contract is to be executed by Feb. 2029.

India’s GDP growth at 7.8% in Q1, slower than last quarter but quicker than last year

Stronger performance was driven by the manufacturing sector as well as some broad services categories such as utilities, financial services, real estate, IT, public administration and defence

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

The growth in India’s Gross Domestic Product (GDP) stood at 7.8% in the April-June 2026 quarter (Q1 FY27), quicker than the 6.9% recorded in Q1 of last year, but slower than the 8.6% of the January-March 2026 quarter.

The stronger performance in Q1 of this year compared with last year has been driven by the manufacturing sector as well as some broad services categories such as utilities, financial services, real estate, IT, public administration and defence. “India’s exemplary GDP growth of 7.8% during Q1 of FY 2026-27 is a Herculean feat,” Prime Minister Narendra Modi said in a post on X. “The collective strength of our people ensured India delivered such growth despite oil price shocks and supply chain issues in the midst of global uncertainties.”

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman also took to social media to point out that nominal GDP in Q1 of FY 2026-27 is estimated to have grown by 10.3%, while real Gross Value Added (GVA) growth came in at 8.2%.

“The credit for this strong performance goes to the people of India and



The laggards: The mining slipped into a contraction of 2.4% in part due to a high base of 12.4% growth in Q1 of last year. GETTY IMAGES

their hard work,” she added in her post on X. “Reforms undertaken by the NDA Government, together with an agile management of the economy, are bearing results.”

Speaking at the press conference following the release of the data, Chief Economic Adviser V. Anantha Nageswaran said that the key message from the data was that “we are witnessing continued resilience in the Indian growth performance” and that this resilience is backed up by high-frequency indicators.

Some economists have, however, pointed out that while the Q1 growth was a positive surprise, growth in the months ahead is expected to slow.

“A deficient south-west monsoon, amid El Niño conditions, poses downside risks to agriculture and rural demand, while

unfavourable base effects are likely to weigh on growth from Q2,” Vikram Chhabra, Senior Economist at financial services firm 360 ONE Asset said.

The manufacturing sector grew by 9.2% in Q1 of 2026-27, a three-quarter high.

“Manufacturing growth has been very impressive at 9.2%, which comes over 8.3% [in Q1 last year],” Madan Sabnavis, chief economist at the Bank of Baroda explained. “Here it is again the infra-based companies which have contributed to growth based on the results of companies for Q1.”

Overall, Mr. Sabnavis said that the data showed that growth has been spearheaded by capital formation, as measured by the Gross Fixed Capital Formation (GFCF), which has increased to 34.3% of GDP in nominal terms

from 31.4% last year, and grew 20.4% in Q1 of this year. “This is a major takeaway as this involves both private and government expenditure with the former being driven by data centres and power, besides metals,” he added.

Broad-based growth

The construction sector grew 7.7% in Q1 of 2026-27 compared with 5.2% in Q1 of last year.

The third broad category of the secondary sector – Electricity, Gas, Water Supply & Other Utility Services – saw growth coming in at 8.9% in Q1 of 2026-27, although some of this is likely a low base effect since the sector had contracted 1.8% in Q1 of 2025-26.

The tertiary sector, comprising services, cumulatively grew 10% in Q1 of 2026-27 compared with 8% in the same quarter of the previous year. Within this, the ‘Financial, Real Estate, Ownership of dwelling, IT & Professional Services’ category grew at 12.1% in Q1 of this year compared with 8.8% of last year.

The agriculture sector, however, saw growth slowing to 3.6% in Q1 of 2026-27 from 4.4% in Q1 of 2025-26. The mining and quarrying sector slipped into a contraction of 2.4%, in part due to a high base of 12.4% growth in Q1 of last year.

ONGC to infuse ₹1 lakh crore for deepwater exploration: Chairman

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

Oil and Natural Gas Corporation (ONGC) has plans to infuse ₹1 lakh crore for deepwater and ultra-deep water exploration by 2030, Chairman and CEO Arun Kumar Singh told reporters on Monday.

The company plans to drill 87 deepwater and ultra-deepwater wells during the period, he added.

Separately, Rajarshi Gupta, Managing Director of the explorer’s foreign operations arm, ONGC Videsh, told reporters that the Delhi-headquartered explorer was in talks with Venezuelan authorities for acquiring operatorship of their assets in the South American country and expecting a development to pan out in the next three months.

Elaborating on the deepwater and ultra-deep-water drilling ecosystem,



Arun Kumar Singh

Mr. Singh said there was “better technology” at the firm’s disposal and the overall initiative was fuelled by the government’s push.

ONGC Videsh holds 40% interest in the San Cristobal oil project, while the remaining is with Venezuela’s Petroleos de Venezuela S.A. (PDVSA). It holds another 11% stake in the Carabobo project.

“The target is to be the designated operator,” Mr. Gupta said, adding “What we are negotiating is the fiscal terms, the operating terms and the subsurface conditions for evacuation.”

Happiest Minds set to merge with ITC Infotech

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Ashok-Soota-promoted Happiest Minds Technologies Ltd. on Monday signed a definitive agreement to combine its business with ITC Infotech India Ltd., to create a scaled, AI first global technology services enterprise with an annual revenue of ₹8,000 crore by

FY28. As part of the transaction, ITC Infotech will acquire an aggregate minority stake of 22.1% in Happiest Minds from the Promoter and Promoter entities across two tranches for a total consideration of ₹1,330 crore (average price of ₹395/share). The companies will have a combined employee strength of over 19,000.

Govt. notifies ₹1.3 lakh-crore semicon scheme’s phase two

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology notified the second phase of the India Semiconductor Mission (ISM 2.0), targeting a broad range of sops for the electronics manufacturing sector. ISM 2.0 has an outlay of ₹1.28 lakh crore, with all ‘pillars’ of categories being fungible insofar as the share of investments they may get under the scheme.

“People should feel dependent on India,” IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said at a press conference following the notification. “People should become dependent on our country, on our industry, on our production, on our design.



Ashwini Vaishnaw

That makes us really valuable in the entire supply chain. That should be our goal as a country.”

Six pillars

ISM 2.0 has six pillars where government incentives will flow: design, with a focus on chips in industries of strategic priority, and those that are owned

by Indians or OCIs; machines and materials, which will incentivise capital equipment manufacturing and chemicals and gases needed in electronics manufacturing; setting up more fabs, for which capital subsidies will be offered up to 40% by the Centre; packaging and testing facilities, which will also receive capital subsidies; research and development, which will be subsidised up to 75% of project cost; and talent development, which will enjoy the same extent of support as R&D.

ISM 1.0 gave 50% capital subsidy to chip projects, but this was cut to 40% in phase 2 on increased enthusiasm among global players and additional support provided by States.

GRT to buy 74% of Tribhovandas Bhimji Zaveri for ₹1,033.71 cr.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Chennai-based GRT Jewellers India Pvt.Ltd. (GRT) will be buying a majority stake in Tribhovandas Bhimji Zaveri Ltd. GRT, in a statement, announced the signing of a share purchase agreement with the promoters of Tribhovandas Bhimji Zaveri Ltd. to buy 74.12% stake in the firm.

As per the SPA, GRT would buy the promoters’ stake for an aggregate value of up to ₹1,033.71 crore. The consummation of the pact will be subject to regulatory approvals closing conditions. GRT will also be launching an open offer

GRT will also be launching an open offer for another 26% as per applicable SEBI regulations

for another 26% as per applicable SEBI regulations.

G.R. ‘Ananth’ Ananthapadmanabhan, MD, GRT Jewellers, said: “This very well fits into our strategy of spreading presence across India with TBZ’s 37 stores.

Shrikant Zaveri, CMD, TBZ, said what began five generations and 162 years ago as a single store in Zaveri Bazaar has now grown through decades into 37 locations across India.

‘FY27 fiscal deficit at 26.8% full year target at end July’

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Centre’s fiscal deficit for 2026-27 stood at 26.8% of the full-year target at July end, according to data released by the Controller General of Accounts (CGA).

The deficit was at 29.9% of Budget Estimates (BE) of 2025-26 for the first four months of FY26.

In absolute terms, the fiscal deficit, or gap between the government’s expenditure and revenue, was ₹4,55,144 crore in the April-July period of FY27.

The Centre has set a fiscal deficit target of 4.3% GDP, or ₹16.96 lakh crore for the current fiscal.

According to the CGA, the Centre’s net tax revenue was about ₹8.45 lakh



Under check: The Centre transferred ₹3,72,354 crore to States, or ₹56,190 crore lower than the previous year. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

crore, or 29.5% of the corresponding BE of 2026-27 of total receipts, up to July.

In the corresponding period of the previous fiscal year, the net tax revenue was at 23.3% of that year’s BE.

The data on monthly accounts showed total expenditure during the first

four months was at about ₹17.62 lakh crore, or 32.9% of BE. In the year-ago period, it was at 30.9% of BE.

The Centre transferred ₹3,72,354 crore to State governments as devolution of share of taxes during the period, which is ₹56,190 crore lower than the previous year.

Honda Motorcycle eyes steady growth as 2W market widens

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

India’s two-wheeler industry’s double-digit growth continues to be supported by evolving mobility needs, premiumisation, export demand and potential rural recovery even as it stays sensitive to monsoon, financing availability, input costs and geopolitics, said Tsutsumu Otani, president & CEO, Honda Motorcycle & Scooter India Pvt. Ltd. (HMSI).

He said geopolitical developments pushed up freight costs and extended transit timelines on some routes, prompting HMSI to



Tsutsumu Otani

boost localisation and supply-chain resilience.

On E20, Mr. Otani said HMSI had not observed any customer concerns due to the fuel use.

He added HMSI was investing about ₹2,400 crore to expand manufacturing capacity.

‘HDFC CEO’s move may cause leadership transition risk’

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

HDFC Bank MD & CEO Sashidhar Jagdishan’s decision not to seek reappointment introduces a degree of leadership transition risk as the succession was not previously anticipated, Moody’s said on Monday.

Mitigating risks

“While leadership changes at systemically important banks can create uncertainty around strategy execution and risk management, HDFC Bank’s strong franchise, deep senior management bench and one of the strongest financial profiles among Moody’s-rated banks in India mitigate these risks,” said



Sashidhar Jagdishan

Devang Rajkotia, AVP, Moody’s Ratings.

An orderly succession process and continuity in strategy execution will be key to sustaining stakeholder confidence and limiting any negative credit implications, he added.

On Monday, several brokerages recommended

investors to accumulate or buy HDFC Bank’s shares which underperformed 28% year to date.

Finding successor

Speculation has been rife as to who will succeed Mr. Jagdishan. The board has stated that it has initiated the process to find the successor well within time.

While the current Deputy MD Kaizad M. Bharucha has emerged as a strong contender, the names of several external candidates are doing the rounds.

IIFL in a note stated while Mr. Bharucha may seem a probable successor choice, the 15-year whole time director ceiling means he will have a maximum of only one tenure.

Branches key amid digital banking rise, says KVB’s Babu

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Branches continue to play a crucial role, particularly for retail, agricultural and MSME clients though digital banking, making everyday transactions easier, Karur Vysya Bank MD and CEO Ramesh Babu said after opening 16 branches.

“The new branches will help us get closer to clients and offer them the convenience of personalised service and digital banking,” he said opening the branch in Hyderabad’s Gachibowli and the rest virtually.

The new facilities are in Tamil Nadu, Telangana,



Ramesh Babu

Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka and Delhi NCR and take KVB’s nationwide branch network to 919.

The private sector lender’s total business as of June 30 stood at ₹2,27,267 crore with deposits of ₹1,22,587 crore and advances of ₹1,04,680 crore.

NIIF raises ₹19,000 crore for second infra fund

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

National Investment and Infrastructure Fund Ltd (NIIF), India’s sovereign-anchored alternative asset manager, said its NIIF Infrastructure Fund II raised ₹19,000 crore (\$2 billion). The target is ₹30,000 crore (\$3.2 billion).

“The first close is anchored by the GoI and supported by a high-quality investor base spanning sovereign wealth funds, pension funds, insurance companies and leading Indian financial institutions,” NIIF said. Also, NIIF expects to raise ₹9,000 crore in co-investment capital.

Depleted U.S. oil stash loses potency as Iran war grinds on



Tough times: An oil storage tank at the Strategic Petroleum Reserve in Freeport, Texas, U.S. REUTERS

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
WASHINGTON/HOUSTON

Six months into the U.S.-Israeli war with Iran, Washington may find it harder to calm jittery oil markets after U.S. Presidents drained the ageing Strategic Petroleum Reserve (SPR) over last five years.

Lowest level
The SPR, which Washington created after the oil crises of the 1970s, holds crude in a series of 60 underground salt caverns along the coasts of Texas and Louisiana. After years of releases by former President Joe Biden and President Donald Trump, the reserve is at its lowest level since 1982, holding just 289.7 million barrels.
The level will drop to about 243 million if Trump releases a final batch of 39 million barrels from a March agreement with the International Energy Agency (IEA). More than 30 countries agreed then to release a record 400 million barrels, with the U.S. contributing 172 million, in an effort to calm markets after the U.S. and Israel launched the war on Iran on February 28.

Oil in the caverns, some of which are as tall as the Empire State Building, floats on top of water. The water level rises as more oil is released, which can damage cavern walls and pipes and pumps that draw out the crude.
A Department of Energy (DoE) source said the minimum operating level is 70 million barrels.
Siddharth Misra, a professor of petroleum engineering at Texas A&M University, said that while the absolute physical floor for the SPR is 70 million barrels, the practical minimum level for safe operations is close to 250 million barrels.
“The core mission of the reserve is to supply the market rapidly during a crisis,” said Misra. “But operating below 250 million barrels pushes the infrastructure into a dangerous zone,” said Misra, noting his comments do not necessarily reflect his university’s position.
Trump said on Sunday the U.S. will refill the SPR using Venezuelan oil, but it was unclear how quickly that could help replenish the reserve or reduce gasoline prices. Washington is expected to reach a deal with Caracas this week aimed at reviving Venezuela’s battered oil industry, that could give the U.S. control of a fifth of its vast proved crude reserves.

SPR release
The Trump administration released the 172 million barrels of SPR oil as a loan that companies must repay with interest in the form of about 40 million barrels of additional oil, about what the U.S. uses in two days. That return will not begin until later this year and is not slated to be completed until late 2028. Kevin Book, an analyst with Clear View Energy Partners, said in a research note late on Sunday that whether the U.S. ships Venezuelan oil directly to the SPR or sells it to fund purchases of U.S. oil for the reserve, a full replenishment “could take years” and be cut short by polls at home and Venezuela.

Long time coming
The dearth of oil in the SPR has been a long time coming. Thanks to the U.S. oil boom that began in 2008, the country is now a net total petroleum exporter, so an IEA requirement for members to store 90 days of net petroleum imports no longer applies. Beginning in 2021, Biden released about 230 million barrels in coordination with international partners to dampen oil prices, including sale of a record 180 million barrels after Russia invaded Ukraine in 2022.
Washington began replenishing the SPR, but the Iran war halted that. And money has run dry. Last year, Congress provided just \$171 million to replenish the reserve, far below the roughly \$20 billion needed at that time. The DOE did not immediately respond to a request for comment.
Some restrictions are already in sight. U.S. law prohibits the president from ordering routine, small drawdowns if the reserve falls below 252.4 million barrels. The president could still order releases for major emergencies.
The SPR’s caverns are generally in good condition but the DoE is concerned about the integrity of the wells due to ongoing needed work, a Government Accountability Office report said in May.

10 years of UPI: How can it expand new frontiers for digital payments?

Faster penetration of affordable smartphones and Internet, Aadhaar-based identity framework, and the government’s push to digital payments created a perfect environment for the exponential growth of UPI, making it a volume giant. However, it is not yet a value goliath

NEWS ANALYSIS

Santosh V. Perumal

The Unified Payments Interface (UPI), celebrating its tenth anniversary in August this year, is unique in many ways as it democratised technology, altered consumers spending behaviour and elevated India’s position from a consumer of global payment technologies to an exporter of digital public infrastructure.
Launched in 2016 with 21 banks, UPI is an open-access platform built by National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI). It now has over 700 lenders, daily processing about 66 crore transactions – a milestone recognised by the International Monetary Fund (IMF).
An ACI Worldwide report said India accounted for 129.3 billion real-time payment transactions or 49% of global volume, followed by Brazil with 37.4 billion transactions (14%), Thailand with 20.4 billion (8%), China with 17.2 billion (6%) and South Korea with 9.1 billion (3%).

Volume giant
Faster penetration of affordable smartphones and Internet, Aadhaar-based identity framework, and the government’s push to digital payments created a perfect environment for



Road ahead: Next decade should focus on globalisation and financial innovation. GETTYIMAGES/ISTOCK

the exponential growth of UPI, making it a volume giant. However, it is not yet a value goliath. Officials, directly and indirectly, view that a platform handling trillions of rupees annually cannot depend indefinitely on a zero-cost model.
Annual UPI transactions scaled from just 1.78 crore in FY17 to more than 24,162 crore in FY26 – nearly a 13,000-fold jump. Value expanded from ₹0.07 lakh crore to around ₹314 lakh crore during the same period.
Retail payments accounted for about 81% UPI’s transactions by volume in FY25, but constituted mere 9-10% of total value, while systems like RTGS dominate large-value transfers.
Displaying financial in-

An ACI Worldwide report said India accounted for 129.3 bn real-time payment transactions or 49% of global volume, followed by Brazil with 37.4 bn transactions (14%)
clusion, anybody from a street hawker or a small merchant to auto drivers with a QR code can now accept digital payments without investing in expensive point-of-sale infrastructure.
Simultaneously, the reduced transaction costs and expanded customer engagement also forced banks to rethink their traditional payment revenue

models.
UPI’s main competitors
Brazil’s Pix is the closest comparison to UPI. Meanwhile, China’s digital payment revolution was driven mainly by private technology platforms – Ant Group’s Alipay and Tencent’s WeChat Pay.
The U.S. payments remain dominated by card networks such as Visa and Mastercard, along with bank-based systems like ACH. The U.K. has Faster Payments, while Singapore has PayNow. Although UPI leads in transaction volume, global acceptance and merchant integration are the areas where global networks have an advantage.
The payment infrastructure is fast becoming a key

component of economic diplomacy. UPI is now operational globally, with adoption and acceptance expanding across almost a dozen countries. The objective is to facilitate payments for Indian travellers and create cross-border payment connectivity that can reduce dependence on traditional correspondent banking channels. For decades, global payment systems were dominated by card networks and closed-loop platforms.
India – which demonstrated that a low-cost, interoperable, real-time payment system could operate at massive scale – has attracted global interests. New Delhi has signed digital public infrastructure cooperation agreements with as many as 23 countries, covering areas such as digital identity, payments and data exchange. Namibia, Peru, South Africa, Kenya, Rwanda and other African countries have had discussions on adopting India’s digital payment infrastructure approach.
Next frontiers
The UPI’s first decade marked building scale, adoption and trust, which have been achieved diligently. The next decade should ideally focus on sustainability, globalisation, and financial innovation. The time has come for the UPI to move beyond its

role as payment gateway and evolve into a new generation of embedded finance, spanning digital lending, insurance products, investments, wealth management and cross-border remittances.
Key challenges ahead
The key challenges include raising transaction limits and building confidence among corporates, regulators, and tax authorities. UPI is now largely used for low-value person-to-person and merchant payments, with normal transactions having ₹1 lakh per transaction limit. Select categories such as IPO applications, capital markets, and tax payments have higher limits, including up to ₹5 lakh in some cases. To attract large-value flows, UPI needs higher merchant transaction ceilings for verified businesses, tiered limits based on risk profiles, instead of uniform cap, corporate UPI accounts with maker-checker authentication similar to corporate internet banking, and bulk payment capability for salaries, vendor payments, GST payments and government transactions.

Monetisation issues
Monetisation is unresolved. The zero-MDR (Merchant Discount Rate) model helped adoption but raises queries on long-term sustainability for banks and payment providers.

Subhash Chandra case: why are creditors set to recover only ₹6.5 cr. against ₹22,006 cr. claims?

EXPLAINER

Rizmi Lia M.

The story so far: The National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) on August 25 approved a repayment plan for Essel Group founder Subhash Chandra under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, 2016 (IBC). Under the plan, ₹6.25 crore will be paid to creditors and ₹25 lakh towards the insolvency resolution process costs.
This is against admitted claims of ₹22,006.57 crore, implying a recovery of about 0.03%, or a haircut of nearly 99.97%, which means a drop in the value of collateral assets, which reduces the lender’s protection against losses. Some creditors, including HDFC Bank, have opposed the plan and are considering an appeal.

What’s the case
The case before the NCLT concerned Mr. Chandra’s liability as a personal guarantor and not against the Essel Group as a corporate entity. The proceedings were initiated by Indiabulls Housing Finance in connection with a ₹170-crore loan to Vivek Infracon Private Limited, for which Mr. Chandra had provided a personal guarantee.
A personal guarantee is a promise by an individual to repay a borrower’s debt if the borrower defaults.
In a press statement issued on August 27, Mr. Chandra’s office clarified he had not borrowed any money. “Chandra is only a personal guarantor. The total claim against him as a personal guarantor in proceedings is only ₹3,992 crore by the objectors of



Man in focus: The resolution professional assessed Mr. Chandra’s disclosed personal assets at ₹31.79 crore via X/@SUBHASHCHANDRA.

the plan and not ₹22,000 crore,” the statement said.
Personal vs. corporate
A firm and the individual who own or control it are separate legal persons. Insolvency proceedings against a company and its personal guarantor are separate proceedings, although they may arise from the same borrowing.
In a corporate insolvency resolution process (CIRP), the focus is on resolving the firm’s financial distress, generally through a resolution plan failing which liquidation. In personal-guarantor insolvency, the individual can propose a repayment plan. “In a corporate insolvency, the Code envisages the resolution of a firm’s debt by taking over its management and finding a buyer or revival plan, whereas in personal insolvency, the first step is to allow the borrower to propose a repayment plan to be voted on by the creditors. If approved by the creditors and the NCLT, the Code provides the guarantor with a fresh start by passing a discharge order under section 119 of the Code,” said Mr. Vasa.
The two proceedings can run simultaneously. Section 60 of the IBC pro-

vides for insolvency proceedings relating to a personal guarantor of a corporate debtor to be dealt with by the NCLT where proceedings against the corporate debtor are pending.
“The legal rationale for simultaneous proceedings is based on the settled principle of law found in contract jurisprudence i.e., the liability of a guarantor is coextensive and independent of the principal borrower’s liability,” said Rohan S. Vasa, a Mumbai-based counsel practising insolvency and commercial litigation.
Thus, Mr. Chandra’s personal insolvency does not itself settle the liabilities of the Essel-linked firms that borrowed the money. Creditors can continue to pursue the principal borrowers via own legal or insolvency proceedings.
Why only ₹6.5 crore?
The admitted claims in Mr. Chandra’s personal insolvency proceedings total ₹22,006.57 crore. Against this, the repayment plan provides ₹6.25 crore to creditors and ₹25 lakh towards process costs.
The 99.97% haircut is therefore a comparison

between the total admitted claims and the amount proposed for distribution under Mr. Chandra’s personal repayment plan. It does not mean that Mr. Chandra personally borrowed ₹22,006 crore.
“The ‘99.97% haircut’ is a comparison against admitted claims, ₹22,006.57 crore, not against realisable assets that the guarantor, Dr. Chandra in this case, actually owns,” said Mr. Vasa.
The resolution professional assessed Mr. Chandra’s disclosed personal assets at about ₹31.79 crore. The NCLT considered if creditors would be better off under the repayment plan than if Mr. Chandra were pushed to bankruptcy and approved the plan.
The case also raised questions about Mr. Chandra’s earlier reported wealth. A 2017 net-worth certificate furnished to RBL Bank put his net worth at about ₹45,888 crore while a 2018 certificate put it at about ₹40,562 crore. His assets in the present proceedings were assessed at about ₹31.79 crore. Creditors sought a forensic audit to examine the discrepancy.
“A gap between an old net-worth certificate and today’s disclosed assets, while being a rational question to ask, isn’t by itself proof of fraud, and it doesn’t automatically trigger a forensic audit. While this may be alarming, suspicion is not proof, and at present, the NCLT held the creditors failed to show, with actual evidence, that specific assets were transferred, concealed or diverted to defraud creditors” said Mr. Vasa.
The NCLT similarly held the earlier certificates did not, by themselves, establish that assets had been concealed or diverted. It also held that a forensic audit was not a mandatory precondition for approving the repayment plan.
The IBC provides for collective decision-making by creditors. A repayment plan does not require unanimous approval. In this case, the plan received 80.814% of voting share, over statutory threshold of more than three-fourths.
The principle is that an individual creditor cannot veto a plan approved by the required majority. Once the NCLT sanctions the plan, it becomes binding on the creditors covered by it, including those who voted against it.
However, creditors can challenge how the majority was obtained or whether the law was followed.
One major objection in this case concerned five entities that dissenting creditors alleged were associates of Mr. Chandra and therefore should not have been allowed to vote. The NCLT did not accept the objection.
“Once a plan clears the 75% voting share requirement as provided by the Code, no creditor gets a veto. The plan binds everyone, including those who voted against it. That’s the whole point of majority rule in insolvency law,” said Mr. Vasa. The original NCLT Bench itself had differed over the plan, requiring the matter to be decided by a third member. The third judicial member, Nishesh Sharma approved it.
If creditors appeal
Creditors can challenge the NCLT order before the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT).
An appeal would have to raise a legal or procedural challenge, such as whether ineligible creditors were allowed to vote, whether the statutory majority was correctly calculated, or whether the NCLT wrongly applied the
A creditor cannot overturn the plan merely because it considers the ₹6.5-crore recovery too low.
“The strongest grounds available to the dissenting creditors are the objections with respect to the votes that came from entities that are allegedly ‘associates’ of Dr. Chandra and that family control over those entities should have been enough to disqualify their votes,” said Mr. Vasa.
If the appellate tribunal finds that votes were wrongly counted and that the required majority was consequently not achieved, it could interfere with the NCLT’s approval.
“Lastly, the most recent newsletter published by the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Board of India (“IBBI”) confirms that since the Personal Guarantor law kicked in, out of the approximately 5,186 cases filed by creditors, only 64 cases ended in a repayment plan, and across those cases, creditors have recovered roughly 1% of what they are owed. Therefore, the Subhash Chandra case is the norm, not the exception,” said Mr. Vasa.
For now, however, the NCLT-approved plan provides for ₹6.25 crore to be distributed to creditors, with ₹25 lakh towards process costs. The plan concerns Mr. Chandra’s personal insolvency and does not, by itself, extinguish the separate liabilities of the companies that originally borrowed the money.

JERUSALEM

Five Palestinians killed in Israeli airstrikes in Gaza City, medics say



Israeli airstrikes killed five people west of Gaza City on Monday, according to the Al-Shifa Hospital and rescuers, while the Israeli Army said it targeted Hamas "operatives". Despite a U.S.-backed ceasefire that took effect in October 2025, at least 1,318 people have been killed according to the Palestinian Health Ministry. AFP

SEOUL

North Korea calls U.S., South Korea, and Japan maritime drills a threat



Maritime drills by South Korea, the United States and Japan are a "threat" to North Korea, Pyongyang said on Monday, branding Washington as hostile and vowed to strengthen its nuclear force. The remarks from North Korea's Foreign Ministry come as U.S. President Donald Trump seeks a meeting with Kim Jong-un. AFP

TORONTO

Google Maps to show Lake Ontario as 'Lake America' for users in U.S.



Google has updated its maps application to rename Lake Ontario as "Lake America" for users in the U.S., reflecting an order by President Donald Trump that changed the lake's name, amid an escalating trade war with Canada. Ontario Premier Doug Ford responded with a billboard-sized message: "Lake Ontario. Now and forever." AP

TAIPEI

'Unpredictable' China strengthens air and sea control nearby: Taiwan



Beijing is tightening its grip on the air and sea around Taiwan, Taipei said in its annual report on China's military threat, adding that the regional security situation "continues to escalate", noting a "rising unpredictability" in China's decision-making due to an "unprecedented" purge of senior military officers. REUTERS

U.S., Iran exchange strikes for first time in weeks, escalating conflict

Washington carries out strikes on Iranian island in the Strait of Hormuz; Tehran retaliates by attacking U.S. military bases in Jordan and UAE; Trump threatens to 'hit hard' while Pezeshkian calls for 'dialogue'; three dead in American strikes, says Iran

Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN

U.S. President Donald Trump threatened to hit Iran "hard" after the two countries traded fire for the first time in over a month, while Iran's President warned that more fighting with the U.S. was not in his country's interest.

Late on Sunday, the United States said it had carried out strikes on an Iranian island in the Strait of Hormuz, with Tehran quickly retaliating by attacking U.S. military targets in West Asia.

"We're going to hit them hard," Mr. Trump said. "There will be a response."



Defiance display: Pedestrians walk next to an anti-U.S. mural on a street in Tehran on Monday. AFP

The United States said it attacked Iranian rocket launchers on the island of Larak to prevent Tehran planting mines in the key shipping lane.

Iran responded with missile and drone attacks

aimed at Jordan and the United Arab Emirates, saying they targeted U.S. forces there, but President Masoud Pezeshkian later on Monday called for dialogue.

"We continue to strive

for a path of agreement and understanding, and we believe that continuing the war is neither in our interest, nor in the interest of the region," he said at a summit in Kyrgyzstan, adding "the solution to the existing problems is dialogue and cooperation".

Iranian state media reported that three people were killed in the U.S. attack on Larak.

Iran's Revolutionary Guards said the ballistic missile attack on two U.S. air bases in Jordan caused "heavy damage". Jordan's Army said it had intercepted eight missiles, without stating their origin.

Iran also said it targeted U.S. personnel at an air

base in the UAE and shot down an American drone over Hormuz. Abu Dhabi said it intercepted a drone over the country's waters, but dismissed claims that Al Minhad Air Base had been targeted as "baseless".

Economic pressure U.S. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent vowed to keep up the economic pain. "We are going to continue exerting pressure, and we've had very good discussions here already," Mr. Bessent said at a meeting of G20 finance leaders.

He said a turning point in the pressure campaign could come "within weeks or months".

Nepal flood toll surges to 939; search on for trapped workers

Associated Press
KATHMANDU

Rescuers raced to free hundreds of workers believed to be trapped in tunnels at hydropower sites that were buried in mud by catastrophic flooding on the Nepal-China border, as the combined deaths in both countries surpassed 950, with more than 4,400 people missing.

A private-sector association representing power companies said at least 900 workers were unaccounted for at 12 hydropower projects in Nepal's Rasuwa and Nuwakot districts. About 500 of those workers were believed to be trapped in tunnels.

At least one expert said that some workers could have access to oxygen, but others warned that the chances of finding survi-



Solemn duty: Paramilitary personnel prepare the bodies of flash flood victims for burial in Chitwan, Nepal, on Monday. AP

vors were diminishing. An Indian Army officer deployed as part of a specialised tunnel rescue team said rescuers were digging through "sludge".

On the Chinese side, rescue and recovery efforts included rebuilding the road leading to the Gyirong Port border crossing that regulated travel between China and Nepal.

Nepal's disaster agency

said on Monday that 939 bodies had been recovered, with 3,925 people missing, including 592 foreigners. As of Sunday, Chinese officials reported 16 deaths and 546 missing. Chinese state media said 261 of the missing were foreigners.

The August 26 disaster was sparked by a glacial collapse, the U.S. Geological Survey said.

UN panel presents legal case for broad slavery reparations

Agence France-Presse
GENEVA

Countries are legally obliged to provide broad reparations for harms resulting from both direct and indirect involvement in the transatlantic African slave trade, a UN committee said on Monday.

Issuing a fresh interpretation of an important international rights treaty, the UN watchdog said the accord obliges countries to work to redress the harms caused by slavery.

"States parties must implement comprehensive reparatory measures for people of African descent, covering all aspects of remedies," the UN Commit-

tee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination (CERD) said in its findings. It stressed that reparatory justice combined "a wide range of measures conceived as monetary, non-monetary and structural".

While not legally-binding, committee member Pela Boker-Wilson said the findings carry "authoritative weight", and can be used by officials to inform judicial review, by courts as an interpretative tool, as well as in litigation aspects.

At least 12.5 million Africans were taken and sold between the 15th and 19th centuries in what the CERD called the largest forced displacement in history.

Sovereign shield



Ministers of defence and foreign affairs of Turkiye, Pakistan and Saudi Arabia, along with their military chiefs, pose before the first committee meeting under the joint defence accord, the "Mecca Joint Defence Agreement", in Istanbul, Turkiye, on Monday. REUTERS

Russia, Israel behind disinformation on Ceuta crisis: Sanchez

Reuters
MADRID

Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sanchez said on Monday there were signs Russia and Israel had spread the disinformation over Spain's migration policy that triggered last month's rush of migrants into Ceuta, but no evidence of Moroccan involvement.

Over 72,000 migrants irregularly crossed from Morocco into the tiny Spanish territory between July 30 and 31 in an unprecedented surge at one of the European Union's only two land borders with Africa. At least 100 people died in the attempt, according to Ceuta's local authorities.

Spanish Opposition parties have accused Rabat of deliberately allowing the mass crossing, an accusation Morocco has denied.

"When people talk and speculate about the participation of Moroccan authorities, I deny this outright," Mr. Sanchez said.

Mr. Sanchez said research by the EU's diplomatic service EEAS had indicated that Russian and Israeli networks had been behind the spread of disinformation in conjunction with far-right networks.

Some 5,000 migrants have stayed in Ceuta since the border rush, triggering protests from locals against the Spanish government's handling of the crisis.

Magsaysay honour for Myanmar activist, Singapore lawyer, Bangladeshi aid giver

Associated Press
PHILIPPINES

A Singaporean diplomat who led adoption of UN oceans treaty, a Myanmar activist who put his freedom on the line for democracy, and a former Bangladeshi teacher who brought compassion to the poor were named on Monday as the winners of this year's Ramon Magsaysay Awards.

Singaporean lawyer and diplomat Tommy Koh, 88, was recognised for promoting international dialogue and the rule of law. He is best known for presiding over a U.N. conference of more than 150 countries, which adopted the U.N. Convention on the Law of the Sea in 1982.



Bo Kyi, Runa Khan and Tommy Koh. RAMON MAGSAYSAY FOUNDATION

"Of enormous significance to maritime countries, this 'constitution for the oceans' defined territorial waters and the economic rights of countries to their coastal waters and provides mechanisms for settling disputes," the awards body said.

Bo Kyi, the 61-year-old winner from Myanmar, has spent seven years in prison

for a life spent in resistance against widespread human rights violations by Myanmar's military.

In March 2000, Bo Kyi and fellow former political prisoners organised the Assistance Association for Political Prisoners, which has "devoted itself to documenting political imprisonment, supporting detainees and their families

and ensuring the continued visibility of the junta's political prisoners in Myanmar," the awards body said.

Runa Khan, 67, of Bangladesh won the award for "her profound empathy for the poorest of the poor in her country."

Coming from an affluent family, she first served as a teacher to poor children in 1979. In 2002, she established an organisation called "Friendship Bangladesh" that helped the most destitute "deal with climate change, educate their children, empower women, create livelihood opportunities and bring social justice to the excluded," according to the awards body.

Captain detained as rescuers hunt for missing in Northern Cyprus ferry capsized

Agence France-Presse
ISTANBUL

The captain of a ferry that capsized off northern Cyprus, leaving at least eight people dead, was ordered into police custody on Monday as rescuers continued to search for 20 others still missing, officials said.

The crowded ferry carrying 267 people capsized on Sunday about four nautical miles offshore shortly after leaving the port of Kyrenia in the north of the divided island.

Rescuers in the Turkish Republic of Northern Cyprus (TRNC), which is only recognised by Ankara, pulled 239 people to safety, but eight others died



Screen grab from a video shows a passenger being rescued after a ferry capsized off the coast of Northern Cyprus on Sunday. REUTERS

"and the search continues for 20 people," said Prime Minister Unal Ustal.

All eight people who died were citizens of Turkey, as well as 18 of those who are missing, according to TRNC authorities. The other two missing are

from Northern Cyprus, they said.

Police detained the captain and 15 others. Nine of them appeared in a court on charges of negligent homicide, as Northern Cyprus began three days of mourning, the official TAK

news agency said. Addressing the court, the captain and crew said the front of the vessel had been smashed open by the force of the waves, Turkey's Anadolu state news agency said. The captain was remanded in custody.

Several survivors said they heard what sounded like an explosion shortly before it capsized.

Turkiye sent six naval vessels and two drones, among others, to help the rescue efforts on Sunday.

Cyprus has been split since 1974, when Türkiye invaded and occupied the northern third of the island in response to an Athens-engineered Greek Cypriot coup seeking unification with Greece.



City of music: A giant installation of guitars at Zheng'an's Guitar Cultural Plaza in , in Guizhou, China. AFP

Chinese guitar capital's stairway to export heaven

Agence France-Presse
ZHENG'AN

It doesn't take long to guess the main industry of the Chinese town of Zheng'an. A giant guitar sculpture dominates the central square, guitar murals adorn walls and pavements and even the rubbish bins are shaped like guitars.

This corner of the southwest province of Guizhou produces one in every seven of the instruments sold worldwide. A decade ago, it had no guitar-making industry to speak of at all.

There are hundreds of specialised manufacturing towns in China, producing items ranging from bicycles to socks. But the speed and scale of Zheng'an's rise make it an example of the impact of China's industrial strategy when a combination of local and Central government investment is deployed to maximise favourable local conditions.

For years, the town's working-age residents left to find employment in factories in Guangdong, southern China's manufacturing hub.

In 2012, Zheng'an local authorities rolled out an initiative called "return the phoenix to the nest", to encourage skilled migrant workers to return home and start businesses. Within around 10 years, 87 home-grown brands had emerged from the industrial cluster. Authorities enticed companies with comprehensive financial, tax and employment support – some were offered three-year tax exemptions and 10 years of free rent.

As per local authorities, Zheng'an manufactures 2.5 million a year, living up to the name plastered on banners across town: "Capital of Guitars, City of Music". Zheng'an is now an export hub – sending 248 million yuan (\$36 million) worth of guitars to more than 40 countries in 2025.

U.S. 'missile of the future' killed civilians far from blast sites in Iran, finds report

Conflict monitor says three Lockheed Martin Precision Strike Missiles struck Lamerd on Feb. 28, killing civilians as far as 50 metres from where they detonated, and caused damage more than three times farther away; U.S. authorities deny claims as experts warn against using it in populated areas

Associated Press
JERUSALEM

It has been touted by the manufacturer as the ballistic missile of the future: lethal, long-range and pinpoint. Lockheed Martin's Precision Strike Missile has the U.S. military investing billions to update its arsenal.

But a close look at what is believed to be its first use in combat – on the first day of the Iran war – highlights the potential peril of deploying this weapon near population centres because it appears to spray pellets over a wide area, according to a review by the conflict monitor Airwars and interviews with weapons experts and former defence officials.

Three missiles that struck the southern city of Lamerd on February 28 killed civilians as far as 50 metres (164 feet) from where they detonated, and caused damage more than three times farther away, Airwars found. The missiles detonated above a sports complex and two residential neighbourhoods, Airwars found. The blasts killed at least 21 civilians, including seven children, according to Iranian officials.

The PrSM is designed to explode mid-air and propel tens of thousands of dense metal pellets at high speed in all directions.

Photos, videos and satellite images of the Lamerd strikes' aftermath analysed by Airwars and verified by AP show buildings, streets, and vehicles were heavily pockmarked in a blast pattern that experts say is consistent with the PrSM's capabilities.

The U.S. military has confirmed firing PrSMs into Iran, but has denied attacking Lamerd. It is unclear who or what was the intended target in Lamerd. An Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps compound is located nearby, but satellite images showed no damage there.

Six weapons experts, including two who are former military officials, told AP they believe PrSMs struck Lamerd – and they said it was unlikely that Israeli or Iranian weapons were used. All said militaries should avoid firing the PrSM at targets near civilian areas. "You would be hard-pressed to find a reason to use the PrSM in a densely populated area," said Michael Meier, a former U.S. Army adviser on the laws of war.

Airwars, a London-based nonprofit, was founded more than a decade ago to track reports of civilian deaths from U.S. airstrikes in Syria and Iraq, and it has also monitored conflicts in Gaza, Ukraine and elsewhere. It relies on publicly available material,



On X, the U.S. Central Command touted the 'historic first' combat use of PrSM in Iran, without specifying where it was used . REUTERS

such as photos, videos, satellite images, social media and news reports, and uses geolocation software and other tools to help it analyse this evidence.

Airwars used these methods to investigate the strikes on Lamerd. It mapped the approximate locations of the missiles' detonations, where civilians were reported killed and where damage was visible and consistent with blast patterns. It then measured the distances between the positions to estimate the blast radius.

Conflicting claims

In a post to X on March 1, the day after Lamerd was struck, U.S. Central Command included what munitions experts say was an image of the PrSM being

fired during the Iran operation. Three days later, it touted that PrSMs – in a "historic first" – had been used in Iran, though not where.

Several weeks later, as reports about the strikes in Lamerd garnered media attention, a spokesperson for Central Command said in a statement that U.S. forces did not launch PrSMs or any weapons into Lamerd on February 28, and that they do not target civilians. The spokesperson said footage of one of the strikes suggested it was an Iranian Hoveyzeh cruise missile.

Weapons experts said a missile seen in security camera video from Lamerd does not match that Iranian model, which has a rounded engine.

Ethiopia's Abiy could consolidate his power as 'executive President'

Agence France-Presse
ADDIS ABABA



Firm grip: Ethiopian Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed has ruled the Horn of Africa nation of 130 million people since 2018. REUTERS

A weeks-long political dialogue in Ethiopia has backed constitutional changes to create a new presidential system that could extend Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed's control over the country.

Mr. Abiy, 50, has ruled the Horn of Africa country of 130 million since 2018.

His party won another landslide victory at elections in June, albeit in the midst of a crackdown on the Opposition and media.

That was followed by a long-promised "national dialogue", in which some 4,000 delegates gathered to discuss the country's many challenges, including its deep ethnic divides

and ongoing insurgencies.

More than a month of talks ended on August 22 with the delegates overwhelmingly backing plans to combine the office of Prime Minister and the largely ceremonial presidency into a new "executive presidency".

It could be put before

Parliament as soon as it reconvenes in October.

Most assume that Mr. Abiy, who was absent from the dialogue, will get the job if it goes ahead, since this new President will be selected by a Parliament packed with his supporters.

They say it will be a

more unifying role, representing all of Ethiopia's ethnic groups, compared to the current system in which Mr. Abiy is elected as a Member of Parliament from his Oromia region.

It will create "a more unified country to overcome the challenges the country currently faces", said Tiglu Melese, Secretary-General of Parliament's upper house. The dialogue also recommended that funding be cut to ethnic-based parties in favour of "national" ones.

Critics fear all this will allow Mr. Abiy to consolidate personal power, as Turkey's Recep Tayyip Erdogan did when he jumped from prime minister to a newly created executive presidency in 2014.

Against the flow



People wade through a flooded street after the southwest monsoon caused heavy rains in Pampanga, the Philippines, on Monday. AFP

Inside the 24-hour mutiny that threatened Niger's junta amid growing insecurity

Associated Press
ABUJA

Niger's capital of Niamey on Sunday appeared calm with normalcy restored after a day of unrest as aggrieved soldiers staged a mutiny that threatened the ruling military junta before being repelled by loyalist forces aided by Russian troops.

In what was seen as a major threat to the junta in power since a 2023 coup, the soldiers engaged loyalist forces in sustained gunfire overnight from Friday till late Saturday. Most of the clashes took place at Niamey's main airport that houses the military air base and in a district where the presidential palace is located.

The unrest culminated in the arrest or killing of dozens of soldiers, some of

whom were paraded in front of the cameras live on state television. The fate of the mutineers was not immediately clear and authorities did not disclose any charges against them.

On Sunday, military trucks and check points were seen across the city, particularly along major roads between the airport and the presidential district. Junta leader Abdourahamane Tchiani was yet to make any public comments or appearance.

Here's what we know about the mutiny, according to witnesses, analysts and diplomats:

Nigeriens were awoken around midnight on Friday into Saturday by bursts of gunfire and explosions that started at the Diori Hamani International Airport. The airport is a strategic hub that hosts a key military air

base, known as Base 101, as well as the headquarters of Russia's Africa Corps in the country. It was the third time this year the airport has experienced unrest.

Gunshots were also heard near the presidential palace in the Plateau district of Niamey as a group of soldiers confronted forces loyal to the junta.

Hours-long chaos

Niger's Defence Ministry said its forces were gradually regaining control of the situation after a group of soldiers took their "comrades" hostage at the air base and fired at "sensitive" sites, without specifying the cause of the unrest.

The chaos persisted for hours late into Saturday as the presidential guard and other loyalist forces secured the air base and the presidency, analysts and



On guard: An armoured vehicle takes position near the Niamey airport, Niger, on Sunday following a mutiny attempt. REUTERS

diplomats said. Some of the mutineers came from hot spots in the south and west, among the areas worst-hit by jihadi violence, and were rallying support from others stationed outside the city, according to one European diplomat.

The unrest appeared to have been triggered by grievances over rising insecurity, including rampant

jihadi attacks. Deadly attacks are "becoming commonplace [in the country] and will continue to fuel unrest and aggravate tensions within the army ranks," said Héní Nsaibia, senior West Africa analyst at Armed Conflict Location and Event Data.

Jihadi violence has worsened in the wider Sahel region, including in neighbouring Burkina Faso and

Mali, where the military also seized power from civilian governments. The junta in Niger promised to stabilise the country but instead security has deteriorated. Attacks on military positions have increased, including one about a week ago when at least 18 soldiers were reportedly killed in Dosso region.

Welfare and attacks

The mutiny was led by soldiers mostly deployed on the ground against the jihadis, according to Wassim Nasr, a senior research fellow at the Soufan Center, a New York-based think tank. "Deteriorating insecurity drove the coups that swept across the central Sahel, and the latest events show how these same pressures are now fueling unrest within the militaries that seized power," said

Mr. Nsaibia. Soldiers' welfare is another key issue, from complaints about food rations to inadequate equipment, according to Beverly Ochieng, a senior analyst at geopolitical risk consultancy Control Risks.

"The stability of these governments is very much pinned on how much they can ensure the army remains cohesive and can provide security and political reforms," Ms. Ochieng said. The mutineers remained camped at the military base within the airport complex for several hours, resisting efforts from loyalist forces, until Russia's Africa Corps intervened with ground and aerial support, several analysts said.

The Africa Corps is believed to have between 200 to 300 personnel in Niger where it is primarily

protecting the junta and its interests, and also supporting the fight against jihadis.

In interviews broadcast on Russian media, Moscow's ambassador to Niger, Viktor Voropayev, said Niger had requested support from the Russian force and the mutineers were "neutralised particularly thanks to the intervention" of Africa Corps. The mutineers outnumbered the elite presidential guard that was deployed to retake the air base and it was unclear who was in control until the Russians intervened, according to Mr. Nasr.

Algeria, the first country on Saturday to express support for Niger, its south-eastern neighbour, assured it of its "full solidarity and firm support." Turkey, another key ally of Niger, expressed solidarity with the country and its people.

Navone hands Djokovic his earliest Slam exit since 2006

The Serb endures his first-ever defeat in the opening round of the tournament; former champion Medvedev posts an easy win over Gaston; Kenin eclipses Venus in straight sets

US OPEN

Agence France-Presse
NEW YORK

An ailing Novak Djokovic suffered his earliest Grand Slam exit in 20 years on Sunday, falling in five brutal sets to Mariano Navone in the first round of the U.S. Open. The 48th-ranked Argentine's 7-6(5), 5-7, 4-6, 6-2, 6-1 victory ended Djokovic's latest bid for a record 25th Grand Slam title. It also ended his run of 78 Grand Slam first-round victories, a streak stretching all the way back to Djokovic's loss to Paul Goldstein at the 2006 Australian Open. Djokovic vomited on court and struggled with late-match cramps but appeared to have finally taken control when he broke Navone for a 2-1 lead in the fourth set with a vintage backhand winner down the line. But Navone won the next five games, raising his



The big upset: Navone kept his composure to hold off Djokovic in five sets to snap the Serb's streak of 78 Grand Slam first-round victories. AFP & REUTERS



arms in celebration after fighting off two break points for a 5-2 lead and breaking Djokovic again to force the fifth set. Djokovic took a medical timeout before the final set, receiving massage on his spine and another delivery of medication. But Navone jumped to a 3-0 lead in the decisive set and despite the urging of fans there was no road back for the Serb as his op-

TOP RESULTS

First round: Men: 7-Medvedev bt Gaston (Fra) 6-4, 6-2, 6-4; 27-Etcheverry (Arg) bt Koprija (Cze) 6-3, 6-4, 6-0; Shapovalov (Can) bt Kecmanovic (Srb) 6-4, 4-6, 6-4, 6-1. Van Assche (Fra) bt 29-Norrie (GBR) 6-7(6), 6-2, 6-2, 6-3; 20-Paul

(USA) bt Wong (Hkg) 6-7(3), 6-1, 6-3, 6-3; Navone (Arg) bt 4-Djokovic (Srb) 7-6(5), 5-7, 4-6, 6-2, 6-1. **Women:** Pliskova (Cze) bt Vandewinkel (Bel) 2-6, 7-5, 6-3; 11-Kostyuk (Ukr) bt Hunter (Aus) 6-4, 6-1; 18-Alexandrova (Rus) bt

Kessler (USA) 6-2, 6-2; Vekic (Cro) bt Gibson (Aus) 6-2, 4-6, 6-3; Kenin (USA) bt Venus Williams (USA) 6-2, 7-6(6); 31-Fernandez (Can) bt Shuai (Chn) 6-3, 6-2; Stefanini (Ita) bt Yastremska (Ukr) 6-3, 4-6, 6-1; 9-Svitolina (Ukr) bt Sierra (Arg) 6-1, 6-2.

idol. "It's a dream come true, I mean seriously, 100%. Djokovic broke Navone

in the second game as he rolled to a 3-1 lead. But the 39-year-old was clearly struggling and with Navone gaining confidence Djokovic had to claw out of 0-40 hole to hold for 4-1, looking weary as Navone began to extend the rallies. **Venus bows out** Venus Williams bowed out of her 26th US Open singles appearance early Monday morning, falling in

straight sets to fellow American wild card Sofia Kenin after not getting on the court until midnight. The 46-year-old lost 6-2, 7-6(6) in what could be the final singles match at a Grand Slam, if not her illustrious career. It was her 14th consecutive singles defeat dating to her last victory in Washington in July 2025. Daniil Medvedev, the 2021 U.S. Open champion,

Tuesday's Picks

MEN
1-Zverev vs Sonogo
5-Cobolli vs Comesana
6-De Minaur vs Guerrieri
9-Fritz vs Blanch
Monfils vs Vallejo
WOMEN
2-Rybakina vs Frodin
4-Gauff vs Sonmez
5-Andreeva vs Tjen
12-Bencic vs Putintseva
17-Eala vs Stoiana

shook off his miserable preparation for the tournament by beating Hugo Gaston 6-4, 6-2, 6-4. The No. 7 seed was just 1-3 in the North American hard-court swing, usually a time he thrives. Other winners on Sunday included No. 9 Elina Svitolina, No. 19 Jasmine Paolini and No. 31 Leylah Fernandez, the 2021 U.S. Open runner-up. Marin Cilic, the 2014 U.S. Open champion, and 2022 runner-up Casper Ruud both withdrew with injuries.

Tilak and Shreyas put South in front; Central and East cancel each other out

DULEEP TROPHY

N. Sudarshan
BENGALURU

South Zone weathered a blistering early morning bowling effort from India pacer Gurnoor Brar (four for 70) to finish day two of the Duleep Trophy semifinal 90 runs in the green at the BCCI Centre of Excellence here on Monday. From an overnight 40 for two, South was reduced to 80 for five. But skipper Tilak Varma played all day (106 batting, 225b, 7x4), and combined with Shreyas Gopal (87, 169b, 11x4) for an excellent, match-turning 175-run partnership. If not for a flurry of wickets towards close – from 255 for five to 270 for nine – South would have been in a healthier position. Nevertheless, with Tilak still around, South can hope to turn the screw further on day three, starting from 285 for nine. It was an uncharacteristic innings from the usually



Need of the hour: Tilak and Shreyas' 175-run stand for the sixth wicket rescued South. K. MURALI KUMAR

dashing 23-year-old Hyderabad batter. His half-century took 149 balls and contained no boundaries, and the first hit past the ropes came on the 154th delivery, helping South secure the first-innings lead. Shreyas was a tad faster but eschewed none of his partner's caution, safely

cutting and steering his way to his fifty from 107 deliveries. But just when the 32-year-old seemed set for his seventh First Class ton, an attempted glide to third-man brought about his downfall. A mini collapse ensued, and it was only then that Tilak shifted gears, and reached his eighth First

Class hundred from 219 balls with back-to-back boundaries off Gurnoor. But in the morning, Gurnoor would have had no inkling of the things to come. Off his fifth ball, he turned N. Jagadeesan inside-out and rearranged his stumps. R. Smaran, the 2025-26 Ranji Trophy top-scorer,

was consumed by another mesmerising delivery that hit the top of off-stump. K. Himateja was sent back next ball to push South to the brink only for Tilak and Shreyas to turn the tables. On the adjacent ground where East Zone was playing Central, proceedings were in stark contrast. Where South scored 73 runs in the opening session, East, propelled by Vaibhav Sooryavanshi's manic 92 (81b, 7x4, 7x6), scored as many as 183. But from 200 for two, Ishan Kishan's outfit was dismissed for 266, the same first-innings total as Central. In what is now a one-innings shoot out, Central was 45 for three at stumps, with captain Rajat Patidar too back in the hut. **The scores:** North Zone 195 vs. South Zone 285/9 in 94 overs (Tilak Varma 106 batting, Shreyas Gopal 87, Gurnoor Brar 4/70). Central Zone 266 & 45/3 in 20 overs vs. East Zone 266 in 57 overs (Abhimanyu Easwaran 69, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi 92, Harsh Dubey 4/66).

N. Sudarshan
BENGALURU

Vaibhav Sooryavanshi's care-free, adolescent excellence graced big-ticket First Class cricket, as the 15-year-old made an entertaining 81-ball 92 on day two of East Zone's Duleep Trophy semifinal versus Central Zone at the BCCI Centre of Excellence here on Monday. In an innings that lasted 118 minutes and was studied with seven sixes and as many fours, Sooryavanshi took on every bowler, and put on 161 glorious runs for the opening wicket with Abhimanyu Easwaran (69, 106b, 8x4). He was dropped on 40 by Yash Rathod at backward point off Saransh Jain while trying a wild cross-batted heave. But what is boyhood if frightening frankness isn't accompanied by tiny flaws? Pacer Yash Thakur was the first to bear Sooryavanshi's brunt, smashed as he was for a flurry of fours and two sixes, one down the ground and the other



Sooryavanshi smashed boundaries aplenty. K. MURALI KUMAR

hooked. Saransh, who had just returned from Sri Lanka following his debut Test, induced a false stroke in his very first over only for Yash Rathod to make a mess of it. Sooryavanshi, however, was unaffected. Reputation has rarely bothered

him, and in the IPL, he didn't spare even the likes of Jasprit Bumrah and Josh Hazlewood. A falling reverse sweep off Saransh was his response, and though that did not fetch the desired result, he hoisted the offie over long-on to bring up his half-century from 42 balls. Sooryavanshi then collected maximums off medium-pacer Aryan Panday and left-arm spinner Harsh Dubey, before launching another blitzkrieg against Saransh. The seasoned Madhya Pradesh spinner was sent soaring above long-off, violently reverse-swept for four, and then muscled over cow-corner. Another attempt at a hoick ended Sooryavanshi's stay as he was caught at deep mid-wicket off Dubey. But it was not before he became the youngest half-centurion in Duleep Trophy history, breaking Rajasthan batter Laxman Singh's record for Central Zone from January 1969 when the latter was 16.

Royals continue resurgence with fourth straight victory

KCL

M.R. Praveen Chandran
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Trivandrum Royals overcame a sloppy fielding display and a counter-attacking innings from Sachin Baby to score a 14-run win over Alleppey Ripples, and continue its mid-tournament resurgence with a fourth straight win, in the Kerala Cricket League at the Sports Hub Greenfield stadium on Monday. Ripples were in the hunt when Baby, who was dropped on 35, and K.A. Arun allied for a 98-run third wicket stand. But the chase was scuppered when the former was caught at long-on by Krishna Prasad off medium pacer Nikhil for 91 (49b, 8x4, 5x6). Arun (37), who was dropped twice, fell to a diving catch by Abhishek P. Nair at point off N.P. Basil. The mounting run-rate



Calling the shots: Pai's unbeaten 82 set up Royals' winning total. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

proved to be tough for the Ripples' lower order as Basil bowled a tidy second spell to finish with four for 32. Earlier, opener Abhishek (57, 30b, 5x4, 2x6) ran into form and helped Royals overcome a slow start. Govind Dev Pai (82 not out, 50b, 6x4, 5x6) chose his attacking moments sensibly to play a well-paced innings as Royals seized control of the middle overs. The duo added 85 runs

for the second wicket before Sabin Girish took three wickets to check Royals' progress. But Sijomon Joseph infused the much-needed momentum with a quick-fire, unbeaten 31 (13b, 4x6) to help Royals add 63 runs from the last four overs. **The scores:** Trivandrum Royals 194/4 in 20 overs (Abhishek P. Nair 57, Govind Dev Pai 82 n.o., Sijomon Joseph 31 n.o., Sabin Girish 3/37) bt Alleppey Ripples 180/6 in 20 overs (Sachin Baby 91, K.A. Arun 37, N.P. Basil 4/32).

VIS-The Hindu u-15 inter-school football tournament inaugurated

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

Vellore International School (VIS), Chennai, and The Hindu inaugurated the third edition of the under-15 inter-school football tournament at the VIS campus in Kayar on Monday. The tournament features 64 school teams from Chennai, Kancheepuram, Tiruvallur, Vellore, Chengalpattu and Tiruvannamalai. The inaugural ceremony was attended by chief guest Daisuke Korenaga (chairman, Football Club Jurong, Singapore), Dr. G.V. Selvam (vice-president, Vellore Institute of Technology, and chairman, VIS), K. Prabhakaran (principal, VIS), Rohit Ramesh (director, The Hindu Group) and L.V. Navaneeth (CEO, The Hindu Group). Speaking at the inauguration, Rohit Ramesh said, "We, at The Hindu, believe that journalism isn't just



Gets the ball rolling: Daisuke Korenaga kicks off the first match as G.V. Selvam, Rohit Ramesh and L.V. Navaneeth look on. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

about reporting the news; it's about supporting the stories that build our community. Sports is one of the most powerful vehicles for that. It teaches discipline, resilience and the value of teamwork – lessons that go far beyond the football

field." The tournament was officially declared open by Korenaga, who kicked off the opening match between KC High International School and P.A.K. Palanisamy Higher Secondary School.

SNAPSHOTS

Como stuns Napoli Como pulled off its latest giant-killing act on Sunday as a 2-1 win ruined Napoli head coach Massimiliano Allegri's home debut in Serie A. **Top results: Serie A:** Napoli 1 (Hojlund 30) lost to Como 2 (Baturina 17, Douvikas 34); Cagliari 0 lost to Inter Milan 1 (Calhanoglu 9); Lazio 1 (Frattesi 25) bt Genoa 0.

Jamil names squad for international friendlies Forward Ryan Williams has found a place in the 26-man India squad, named by head coach Khalid Jamil for the international friendlies against Panama, Brazil and Uruguay. India will face Panama in Bengaluru on Sept. 26 before taking on five-time world champion Brazil on Oct. 3 and two-time title-winner Uruguay on Oct. 6, both in Kolkata. Jamil's side will begin its camp in Bengaluru on Sept. 14. **The squad: Goalkeepers:** Albino Gomes, Gurpreet Singh Sandhu, Prabhukhan Singh Gill, Som Kumar; **Defenders:** Abhishek Singh, Akash Mishra,

Anwar Ali, Bijoy Varghese, Valpuia, Jay Gupta, Pramveer Singh, Ricky Meetei. **Midfielders:** Anirudh Thapa, Ashique Kuruniyan, Farukh Choudhary, Apuia, Macarton Nickson, Mohammed Sanan, Ricky Shabong, Sahal Abdul Samad. **Forwards:** Edmund Lalrindika, Irfan Yadwad, Manvir Singh, Rahim Ali, Ryan Williams, Vikram Partap Singh.

Chennai Bulls reigns supreme Chennai Bulls tallied 311 points to take the top spot and win ₹15 lakh in the national-level Equestrian Champions League (ECL) in Coimbatore on Sunday. Bangalore Knights (291) and Golconda Chargers (286) finished second and third and were richer by ₹10 lakh and ₹five lakh. **Liverpool signs PSG's Barcola for £123 million** Liverpool finalised the most expensive transfer of the summer window by signing Bradley Barcola from Paris Saint-Germain on Monday in a deal worth £123 million.



Nobody can take away the piece of history I achieved

Enekeuchi stresses he wants to stay consistent at the top level before his decline; says Nigerian throwers are grappling with infrastructure and funding issues

BISWARANJAN ROUT

INTERVIEW

Chukwuebuka Enekeuchi

Y.B. Sarangi

Chukwuebuka Enekeuchi presents a fine example of how perseverance can reward an athlete. Despite funding issues, the Nigerian lived in the USA for years to pursue his studies and shot put career before ultimately writing a bit of sporting history. He became the first shot putter from his country to win gold at the Commonwealth Games, achieving the feat in Glasgow.

It was a moment of immense pride for the 33-year-old as he recorded a mark of 21.07m and pipped one of his idols, New Zealand's Worlds and Olympic medallist Tom Walsh. Fresh from his CWG glory, Enekeuchi, who hails from the Anambra State, lived up to his billing by securing the top place with 20.78m at the World Athletics Continental Tour Silver meet at the Kalinga Stadium in Bhubaneswar.

During an interaction, he spoke about his journey, ambitions and his experience of competing in India.

How did you feel after becoming Nigeria's first shot putter to win gold at the Commonwealth Games?

It was amazing, especially at that moment. My life hasn't changed much, but it was a piece of history. It was a huge honour. Many people tried before me and came close. For me to be the first person in history, it's something that nobody can take away from me. And I made a lot of people proud and happy. That means the world to me.

You had clinched a silver in the 2018 CWG. What happened after that?

It was eight years ago. A lot can change in one year. I tried to get a medal in Birmingham (2022) but I didn't. I was fourth. The pressure doubled leading up to Glasgow. But I knew I had to stay consistent, work hard and take it extremely seriously. I prepared very well, but I was also a bit lucky to have that win. So I'm very grateful.

How did you get into shot put?

I just wanted to lift weights and I had to do something. I had to join a team to lift weights. So I joined athletics on a whim, and things just kept getting better and better.

What challenges do Nigerian throwers face?

It's mostly infrastructure issues. A lot of the attention goes towards sprints and events that already have funding from shoe companies. The throws (events) don't get much funding. That would make a big difference... some of it is like investing in coaching and facilities.

The other thing is that I've had a lot of international success. Maybe leaning into that, positioning me in a position where I can help out some of the young guys coming up. That would be a very big benefit for the nation.

Where do you train and how is the funding now?

Funding... it's not there. But I train in Lafayette, Indiana (USA). I went to school at Purdue University and that's where I train now. I moved there for schooling and after I graduated, I just stayed there and continued to train. I'm 10 years out of school, so I've been there for 15 years now.

What advice will you give to young Nigerian throwers?

Give yourself a chance because when you look at me, I'm not the biggest



thrower. I'm probably the shortest guy in the field: I'm 180 centimetres tall. And if you looked at me, especially before I put on a lot of muscle, you would not have thought of me as world-class or as a 22-metre shot putter. But I took a chance on myself and I was able to execute it. What it means is that many more kids can do what I did or even better.

Do you get the opportunity to go back to Nigeria?

Yeah, I go to Nigeria once or twice every year... for the National championships, for the sports festival. I take that opportunity to coach some of the local talent. Just kind of give them advice, give the coaches advice... just like there's so much support for the Indian talent. That's how I feel for

my countrymen. I want them to succeed just as much as anybody would for their country. I do as much as I can to help.

What's your next goal?

I would love to get another major medal and improve my personal best. I'm 33 years old now, but every year I seem to find something new to add to my repertoire. I just want to keep improving. Before I start to decline, I just want to be consistent at a high level.

Do you have anything specific in mind?

I want to keep making finals and compete for a medal at major championships. That would be awesome.

Who are your inspirations?

Some of the guys who are still competing. I looked up to Joe Kovacs for a long time. He's one of the throwers who's not the biggest but super powerful and consistent. I followed him and added my own stuff



One thing I can tell about India is that Indians are very proud of their culture. We had a good immersive experience — the music, meeting some of the dignitaries, the art styles, culture, food. This is my first time in India. New experiences are always welcome. I had a lot of fun.

to get to a world-class level.

And the funny thing is I'm like that for some younger throwers now. It's kind of full circle. Joe was a big inspiration for me... Reese Hoffa, Ryan Whiting and Adam Nelson. A lot of the guys who are still involved in the sport... even Walsh. We're not that different in terms of age, but he was achieving at such a high level when I was still in university. These guys are friends now. But I looked up to them and I kind of learned from them.

Have you made some Indian friends?

Yeah. I met two of the local guys. I've known Tajinderpal Singh Toor for years now. I just met Samardeep Gill in Glasgow. In shot put, we're all competitors but we're also colleagues. So there's always respect in the first place. I know the guys were cheering each other on in between rounds. Even though we compete hard, there's a lot of support within the group.

How was the experience of coming to India and competing here?

It was very nice. One thing I can tell about India is that Indians are very proud of their culture. We had a good immersive experience. The music, meeting some of the dignitaries, the art styles, culture, food. We were immersed in the culture. I've been at it for 10 years now. This is my first time in India. New experiences are always welcome. I had a lot of fun.

